

Compliance without Consensus: Global Investors, Board Gender Diversity, and External Scrutiny

Yujia Chen^{1*} Kurt A. Desender¹

¹ Department of Business Administration, Universidad Carlos III.

* Corresponding author. Email: yuchen@emp.uc3m.es

Abstract

As large institutional investors increasingly promote standardized governance practices across countries, convergence in governance practices does not necessarily imply convergence in how those practices are interpreted across institutional environments, particularly when global governance expectations intersect with distinct local institutional contexts. Using Japan's "Womenomics" reforms as a policy shift that elevated the salience of gender diversity within corporate governance, we show that firms with higher Big Three institutional ownership experience larger increases in board gender diversity following the reform, primarily through director replacement rather than board expansion. We further find that investor-induced increases in board gender diversity were associated with heightened governance-related scrutiny, reflected in higher levels of externally reported governance-related incidents, especially in male-dominated industries and among more visible firms. These increases are not accompanied by systematic declines in firm performance or governance quality indicators. Governance convergence may therefore generate organizational change without generating interpretive consensus.

Keywords: board gender diversity; governance convergence; global institutional investors; media scrutiny

INTRODUCTION

Governance practices increasingly diffuse across institutional environments as large institutional investors promote similar governance expectations across firms and countries (Appel, Gormley and Keim, 2016; Dyck et al., 2019). Prior research has largely seen this process as one of governance convergence, emphasizing how powerful investors encourage firms to adopt widely endorsed governance practices and diffuse governance expectations across firms and countries (e.g., Aggarwal et al., 2011; Azar et al., 2021; Dyck et al., 2019). However, adoption does not necessarily imply agreement regarding the desirability of those practices. When global and local actors hold divergent expectations or values, adopting globally promoted governance practices may generate tension rather than convergence because organizational responses remain embedded in local institutional environments (Schiehll, Martins and Lewellyn, 2025; Witt, Fainshmidt and Aguilera, 2022; Wu et al., 2025). This raises a central question: when expectations diverge across institutional environments, how do firms adapt their governance practices in response to global pressures for conformity, and how are these changes interpreted within local contexts?

Prior research offers important insights into how firms respond to such tensions. Studies on institutional investors show that large asset managers increasingly promote standardized corporate governance practices across firms and countries, such as governance quality metrics (Aggarwal et al., 2011; Witt et al., 2022), ESG practices (Azar et al., 2021; Cohen, Kadach and Ormazabal, 2023; Dyck et al., 2019; Ilhan et al., 2023), and executive pay (Cohen et al., 2023). At the same time, studies show that globally promoted practices may conflict with local governance arrangements because institutional environments differ in the expectations they place on firms (Aguilera and Jackson, 2003; Chung, Luo and Zheng, 2024; Desender et al., 2016).

Under these conditions, firms respond to conflicting governance expectations through a range of strategies, including nonconformity (Witt et al., 2022), selective materiality (Wu et al., 2025), symbolic compliance (Ahmadjian and Robinson, 2001; Mun and Jung, 2018), and temporary compliance followed by reversal (Uchida, 2018).

Yet organizational responses do not necessarily resolve tensions between global governance standards and local institutional expectations. Governance changes remain subject to interpretation by external audiences, whose reactions can reinforce, reshape, or contest emerging governance norms (Phillips, Lawrence and Hardy, 2004). Although prior research has examined how firms adapt to competing governance pressures, we know considerably less about how those governance changes are interpreted once implemented. This gap is important because the legitimacy of governance practices depends not only on their adoption, but also on how they are evaluated within the institutional environments in which firms operate (Bednar, 2012; Bednar, Boivie and Prince, 2013). Domestic intermediaries, such as the media and other societal actors, play a particularly important role in this process because they interpret governance changes through country-specific institutional logics, cultural expectations, and understandings of appropriate corporate conduct. Consequently, governance practices promoted as desirable by global actors may not be interpreted in the same way within domestic contexts, particularly when different audiences evaluate those practices through distinct institutional expectations (Jones and Murray, 2026). Examining these interpretations is therefore essential for understanding when governance convergence produces shared governance expectations and when it generates contestation instead.

We examine this question in the context of gender diversity reforms in Japan. Japan provides a setting in which entrenched male-dominated norms coexist with growing global

external demands for gender equality, while gender reform offers a policy context that amplifies the existing tension between global and domestic actors. In 2013, the Japanese government introduced the “Womenomics” initiative, elevating gender diversity as a national policy while remaining largely non-binding in its implementation. Over the same decade, the “Big Three” institutional investors, including BlackRock, Vanguard, and State Street, actively promote gender diversity through their stewardship activities (Gormley et al., 2023). Leveraging the enhanced visibility and salience of gender diversity induced by the “Womenomics”, we examine how the Big Three affect firms’ adoption of board gender diversity, and how these changes are interpreted by domestic intermediaries, particularly domestic media and other societal actors (Bednar et al., 2013; Deephouse, 2000; Dyck, Volchkova and Zingales, 2008; Kennedy, 2008).¹

Our analysis proceeds in two stages. First, we show that firms with greater Big Three ownership experience larger increases in female board representation following the introduction of “Womenomics”. These changes typically occur through director replacement rather than board expansion, suggesting that firms more exposed to investor pressure adopt more organizationally consequential forms of adjustment. Second, we find that firms more exposed to investor-induced increases in board gender diversity experience higher levels of governance-related scrutiny, measured by governance-related risk incidents reported by the domestic media and other public sources. Importantly, the increase in reported governance-related incidents is not accompanied by a systematic decline in firm performance or governance quality indicators.

This study contributes to research on corporate governance, strategic leadership, and institutional environment by showing that governance convergence does not necessarily imply convergence in how governance changes are interpreted across institutional environments. In doing so, we highlight how macro-level institutional conditions shape not only the adoption of

governance practices but also the meanings attached to those practices by domestic audiences. Using a gender initiative as a lens, we show that transnational investor-driven changes can amplify firms' exposure to external scrutiny in contexts where local norms are misaligned with global standards. Together, we show that governance convergence can occur without interpretive convergence, i.e., firms may adopt governance practices promoted by global investors, yet those same practices may attract heightened scrutiny when evaluated by domestic audiences operating under different governance expectations.

GENDER REFORM, INVESTOR PRESSURE, AND SOCIAL INTERPRETATION IN JAPAN

Japan provides a useful setting to examine how externally promoted governance reforms are implemented and interpreted domestically, particularly where support for gender diversity diverges from global expectations. Japan's corporate leadership has historically featured insider-dominated boards with few women (Ahmadjian and Robinson, 2001; Aoki, 2001). Its internal labor markets and seniority-based promotion systems historically limit women's progression into senior managerial roles (Brinton, 2001; Nemoto, 2013). As a result, expectations about who qualifies for board positions remain closely tied to male-dominated career trajectories, making the appointment of female directors more visible and subject to varying perceptions among local actors.

In 2013, the Japanese government introduced a set of policy initiatives commonly referred to as "Womenomics," under the administration of Prime Minister Shinzo Abe, aimed at increasing female participation in the workforce and in leadership roles (Abe, 2013). A central component of this initiative is encouraging firms to increase female representation in managerial and board positions (Japan Cabinet Office, 2013). The key difference from earlier initiatives is

the introduction of concrete targets: raising the employment rate of women aged 25–44 to 73 percent and increasing women in leadership positions to 30 percent by 2020 (Government of Japan, 2014). These policies rely on voluntary compliance, and prior research suggests that such soft-law approaches increase attention to governance practices without mandating uniform responses (Mun and Jung, 2018). In this case, the initiative enhances board gender diversity as a prominent governance dimension, making it more visible and salient to society.

At the same time, elements of the reform increase the transparency of firms' gender-related practices. Disclosure requirements increase the accessibility of gender diversity metrics, enabling cross-firm comparison and making differences in board composition more salient to external observers. As a result, firms' responses to gender diversity expectations became more observable, comparable, and subject to interpretation by domestic external audiences.

These features of the reform are important for understanding firms' behavior in this setting. Because “Womenomics” relied on voluntary compliance, firms retained discretion over whether and how to adjust board composition, resulting in variation in both the likelihood and extent of change and allowing external pressure to shape outcomes. At the same time, increased transparency makes these choices more visible to societal actors. Thus, the reform does not mandate change but reshapes the conditions under which firms' governance decisions are observed and interpreted externally.

Over the same period, large global institutional investors, particularly BlackRock, Vanguard, and State Street, expand their ownership stakes in Japanese firms. These investors encourage firms to adopt governance practices aligned with global standards (Appel et al., 2016; Dyck et al., 2019), including the active promotion of board gender diversity as part of their stewardship activities (Gormley et al., 2023). Because ownership by these investors varies

substantially across firms, their presence leads to variation in the external pressure faced by firms to change gender diversity practices.

HYPOTHESES DEVELOPMENT

We develop three sets of hypotheses examining whether firms respond to pressure from the Big Three, how they adjust to such pressure, and how resulting changes in board gender diversity are perceived and interpreted by external audiences.

Investor Pressure, Reform, and Board Gender Diversity

Large institutional investors influence corporate governance by applying standardized expectations across firms in their portfolios, shaped by their domestic values and norms (Dyck et al., 2019). Through stewardship activities, these investors promote governance practices intended to enhance accountability and align firms with a single set of governance standards without tailoring to the institutional characteristics of individual firms or countries (Appel et al., 2016; Dyck et al., 2019; Azar et al., 2021; Gormley et al., 2023). For example, Dyck et al. (2019) show that institutional investors transplant their social norms regarding ESG issues around the world.

The Big Three institutional investors represent an influential subset of these investors due to the size and structure of their holdings (Aguilera et al., 2025). Their passive strategies further reinforce reliance on standardized governance policies rather than firm-specific monitoring (Appel et al., 2016; Azar et al., 2021).

Board gender diversity has become a central component of the Big Three's governance focus, following the growing emphasis on diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) in American society (Gormley et al., 2023). The Big Three have strong incentives to promote board gender diversity as part of their global stewardship agendas. Their size and visibility expose them to scrutiny from regulators, advocacy groups, and clients regarding their approach to responsible

investment and governance (DesJardine, Grewal and Viswanathan, 2023; Edmans, Levit and Reilly, 2019). Promoting gender diversity allows the Big Three to signal alignment with US and global endorsed governance standards and to reinforce their reputations as responsible stewards of capital (Dyck et al., 2019; Kahan and Rock, 2020). In addition to these incentives, the Big Three possess the ability to translate stewardship priorities into firm-level pressure. Prior evidence indicates that the Big Three vote against director nominations at firms lacking female board representation and publicly communicate expectations regarding board diversity (Gormley et al., 2023). Consequently, differences in Big Three ownership translate into differences in firms' exposure to investor pressure to adjust board composition.

The effectiveness of the Big Three's pressure, however, depends on the policy context in which it is applied. The introduction of "Womenomics" elevates gender diversity as a policy priority in Japan, thereby enhancing the legitimacy of the Big Three's advocacy for such change in Japan (Suchman, 1995; Deephouse and Suchman, 2008). Moreover, this initiative increases the visibility of board gender diversity and strengthens disclosure of gender-related information. Under these conditions, firms with greater Big Three ownership become more exposed to governance expectations that could be more easily articulated, monitored, and enforced.

From the perspective of organizational responses to normative pressures, firms' awareness of gender equality and incentives to improve board gender diversity increase when such pressure comes from salient and influential investors backed by the "Womenomics" reform (Durand, Hawn, and Ioannou, 2019). The increased transparency and comparability linked to the reform, lower monitoring costs for these investors and raise the expected costs of non-compliance for more exposed firms. Accordingly, firms with greater Big Three ownership should be more likely to increase board gender diversity following the introduction of "Womenomics".

Hypothesis 1 (H1): *Big Three ownership is positively associated with board gender diversity in Japan following the implementation of the “Womenomics” policy.*

Modes of Implementation: Board Restructuring versus Expansion

Organizations vary not only in whether they respond to external pressures, but also in how they implement such responses. A central insight from Durand et al. (2019) is that organizational responses depend on both willingness to respond and the ability to implement change. When these conditions are only partially met, firms may adopt visible adjustments that signal alignment with external expectations without requiring substantial modification of existing structures (Meyer and Rowan, 1977; Oliver, 1991; Westphal and Zajac, 1994).

In the context of board gender diversity, firms can respond to external pressure through varying degrees of structural adjustment. According to Knippen, Shen and Zhu (2019), firms can increase female board representation either through board expansion that retains incumbents or through director substitution. Substitution is perceived as more substantial, as it requires firms to reallocate board seats and alter established board structures. It also signals a stronger commitment to gender diversity, because its implementation involves overcoming challenges arising from system inertia, particularly in Japan, where seniority-based promotion systems and stable director tenure make such changes difficult (Gilson and Roe, 1999; Mun and Jung, 2018).

We argue that exposure to the Big Three primarily affects firms’ likelihood to adjust board composition (Hypothesis 1). However, whether this likelihood translates into more structurally demanding changes depends on how the pressure interacts with the policy context, particularly the institutional context shaped by “Womenomics”. By increasing the visibility of board composition and introducing disclosure requirements, the reform reduces informational frictions for external observers by making board differences more observable and comparable across

firms. As a result, compliance strategies also become more transparent. As expanding the board while retaining incumbent directors may be perceived as a weaker form of compliance, firms facing stronger investor pressure therefore have incentives to substitute directors, which may be viewed as a more credible response by the Big Three.

Taken together, we expect the Big Three not only to increase the likelihood that firms respond to gender diversity pressure, but also to shape how these changes are implemented. Firms more exposed to the Big Three are therefore more likely to make changes that restructure existing board composition following the “Womenomics” reforms.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): *Big Three ownership is positively associated with increases in board gender diversity implemented through board restructuring rather than board expansion following the implementation of the “Womenomics” policy.*

Gender Diversity and Governance-related scrutiny

Media and other societal actors, as public voice channels, play a central role in bringing firm behavior into the public domain. In particular, critical media coverage and societal actors’ views influence how firms are portrayed in the domestic context and which issues gain public attention (Deephouse, 2000; Bednar, 2012; Bednar et al., 2013; Eesley and Lenox, 2006). Given that these external actors have discretion over how they perceive and interpret firms, reported governance-related risk incidents may reflect either firms’ actual governance-related problems or external scrutiny in the absence of actual deterioration in governance.

Following “Womenomics,” board gender diversity becomes a more visible dimension of corporate governance, and a more salient object of external accounts, and we expect these effects to be stronger among firms with greater exposure to Big Three pressure. The implications of this visibility, whether positive or negative, depend on the institutional context in which such changes

occur (Deephhouse and Suchman, 2008; Suchman, 1995). Diversity initiatives are often promoted globally as indicators of sound governance and organization progress (Kalev, Dobbin and Kelly, 2006). However, governance practices are also interpreted through locally embedded norms and expectations (Winkler and Krzeminska, 2024). In Japan's historically male-dominated corporate environment, substantial increases in board gender diversity may constitute a visible deviation from established governance practices. Because such deviations can be interpreted both as governance improvements and as grounds for critical questioning, they become subject to competing interpretations regarding what constitutes appropriate governance and how organizational priorities are evolving (Castilla and Benard, 2010; Dobbin and Kalev, 2016; Eagly and Karau, 2002).

Domestic media and other societal actors play an important role in this process because they shape which governance issues receive public attention and how firms are evaluated (Bednar, 2012; Bednar et al., 2013; Deephouse, 2000). Visible departures from established governance practices are more likely to become subjects of public evaluation, particularly when their implications for corporate governance remain contested. For instance, domestic media and societal actors may question how changes in board composition affect existing governance arrangements, board dynamics, or organizational priorities. They may also interpret such changes as signaling a broader shift in the governance model of the firm, including a movement towards governance practices favored by global investors and greater emphasis on shareholder interests. As a result, board gender diversity may become a focal point through which broader debates about appropriate corporate governance are expressed. Such increased scrutiny does not require deterioration in underlying governance quality. We therefore expect firms more exposed to Big Three–induced increases in board gender diversity to face greater governance-related scrutiny

from domestic media and other public sources following the introduction of “Womenomics”.

Accordingly, we propose:

Hypothesis 3 (H3): *In Japan, increases in board gender diversity are positively associated with governance-related scrutiny by domestic media and other societal actors.*

DATA AND SUMMARY STATISTICS

Empirical Strategy

We exploit the non-binding “Womenomics” reform as a policy-driven catalyst that raises the salience of gender diversity in Japan. The reform elevates board gender diversity as a visible and salient governance issue, thereby increasing its relevance for firms and external stakeholders. Rather than mandating changes in board composition, it gives firms discretion in their responses.

Our empirical strategy compares pre- and post-2013 changes in outcomes across firms with varying levels of ownership by the Big Three institutional investors. This design allows us to examine how exposure to global standardized governance expectations shapes Japanese firms’ responses to increased visibility of gender diversity. The estimated coefficients capture differential post-reform changes across firms with varying levels of Big Three ownership.

Data and Sample

Our sample consists of Japanese listed firms over the 2006–2020 period. To construct a balanced pre- and post-treatment window, we focus on seven years before (2006–2012) and seven years after (2014–2020) the reform, treating 2013 as a transition year. This balanced panel facilitates a consistent comparison of pre- and post-reform dynamics.

We exclude financial firms because their regulatory environment and governance structures differ substantially from those of non-financial firms, which may differentially affect both ownership by global institutional investors and board composition decisions. Data on director

characteristics, ownership structure, and financial variables are obtained from LSEG Refinitiv. Governance characteristics, including board size and board independence, are hand-collected from firms' corporate governance reports filed with the Tokyo Stock Exchange.

We classify firms based on their exposure to Big Three ownership. For each industry-year, we calculate the mean Big Three ownership. Firms consistently at or above this mean from the pre- to post-reform period (2012–2020) are classified as the high-level group, while those consistently below form the low-level group. Firms that switch categories during this period are excluded. This design ensures that firms in the high- and low-level groups stay in their respective categories throughout the sample period. Defining treatment in 2012 ensures exogeneity to the reform. The final sample comprises 552 firms and 8,280 firm-year observations. Table I summarizes the sample construction process, including exclusions and the construction of the balanced panel.²

INSERT TABLE I ABOUT HERE

Key Variables

Board Gender Diversity: We measure board gender diversity using two indicators. The first is the proportion of female directors on the board. The second is an indicator equal to one if the firm has at least one female director in a given year, and zero otherwise.

Big Three Ownership: Big Three ownership is measured as the percentage of shares held by the three largest global asset managers, BlackRock, Vanguard, and State Street Global Advisors. Consistent with prior research, we interpret this measure as capturing exposure to globally standardized stewardship practices and governance expectations.

Governance-related scrutiny: We measure governance-related scrutiny using governance-related incidents from RepRisk, a widely used database that aggregates reports from news media,

NGOs, research firms, and other public sources. RepRisk compiles and codes governance-related risk incidents based on publicly available information, classifying them into issue categories such as corruption, executive compensation, misleading communication, fraud, tax practices, and anti-competitive behavior. Importantly, RepRisk captures external reporting of governance-related risk incidents rather than verified deterioration in governance.

Although RepRisk does not provide the exact source for each incident, its “reach of information source” variable allows us to approximate whether the source is domestic or international. As shown in Online Appendix S1 Table AVII, for governance-related risk incidents, only 14.2 percent stem from global outlets, while the majority relate to local (23.8%) and regional/national resources (62.0%). Overall, over 85 percent of incidents are domestically sourced. Accordingly, RepRisk data provides a reasonable proxy for governance –related scrutiny that primarily reflects domestic actors.³

Control Variables: We include a standard set of firm-level controls that may be associated with both ownership structure and governance outcomes. These include ownership structure, firm size, index inclusion, board size, and board independence. Detailed definitions of all variables are provided in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

Summary Statistics and Descriptive Evidence

Table II reports summary statistics. On average, the Big Three hold 2.3 percent of shares across the full sample, with an average ownership of 7.8 percent among high-level firms and 0.6 percent among low-level firms. These ownership levels are comparable to those documented in prior studies examining the influence of large institutional investors (Gormley et al., 2023). Board gender diversity is relatively low compared to other countries with similar economic scales, with an average female ratio of 3.2 percent. Definitions of all variables are provided in

Online Appendix S1, Table AI.

INSERT TABLE II ABOUT HERE

Figure 1 plots the average female director indicator and the proportion of female directors for firms with high versus low Big Three ownership. Consistent with the parallel trend assumption, board gender diversity follows similar trajectories across the two groups prior to 2013. After 2013, firms with higher Big Three ownership exhibit a faster increase in board gender diversity relative to firms in the low-level group.

INSERT FIGURE I ABOUT HERE

Prior to the reform, Big Three ownership varies substantially across firms. Consistent with prior research, firms with higher Big Three ownership tend to be larger, more likely to be included in global indices (e.g., MSCI and S&P 1200), and to have larger and more independent boards (Aggarwal et al., 2011; Gormley et al., 2023). Table III compares these characteristics between high- and low- level groups in 2012. Our empirical specification accounts for these differences using firm fixed effects and time-varying controls.

INSERT TABLE III ABOUT HERE

EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS

Specification

We estimate the following specification using the ordinary least squares model (OLS)⁴:

$$GenderDiv_{it+1} = \beta_1 Big3\ ownership_{it} \times Post2013_t + \beta_2 Big3\ ownership_{it} + \beta_3 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

$GenderDiv_{it+1}$ denotes board gender diversity of firm i in year $t + 1$, measured alternatively as an indicator for the presence of at least one female director or as the proportion of female directors on the board. We use a one-year lead of the dependent variable to allow time

for ownership structure and governance pressure to translate into board appointment decisions, which typically occur on an annual cycle tied to shareholder meetings.

$Big3\ ownership_{it}$ measures the fraction of firm i 's equity held by the Big Three asset managers in year t . $Post2013_t$ is an indicator equal to one for 2013 and all subsequent years and zero otherwise. The coefficient of interest, β_1 , captures the differential change in board gender diversity after 2013 associated with greater Big Three ownership and constitutes the difference-in-differences estimator.

X_{it} is a vector of time-varying ownership controls that capture the broader ownership structure of the firm and may influence board composition. These controls include *domestic ownership concentration*, *domestic bank ownership*, *domestic corporate ownership*, *domestic employee ownership*, *cross-shareholdings*, and *non-Big-Three foreign ownership*. Definitions of all variables are provided in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

We include firm fixed effects (α_i) to account for time-invariant firm characteristics and year fixed effects (δ_t) to absorb common macroeconomic and regulatory shocks. Standard errors are clustered at the firm level to account for serial correlation in the error term.

Our identification relies on the assumption that, absent the reform, firms with differing levels of Big Three ownership would follow similar trends in board gender diversity. We examine the plausibility of this assumption using an event study specification.

Baseline Results

Table IV reports the baseline estimates of the relationship between Big Three ownership and board gender diversity. Across specifications, firms with higher exposure to the Big Three exhibit larger increases in board gender diversity in the post-reform period.

In Panel A, Column (1), the interaction between Big Three ownership and the post-reform

indicator is positive and statistically significant ($\beta_1 = 0.486$, $p < .001$), indicating that firms with greater Big Three ownership experience larger increases in the proportion of female directors following the reform. The estimated effect in Column (11) is economically meaningful: a one-standard-deviation increase in Big Three ownership is associated with an increase in the female ratio on the board of approximately 0.012 (0.043×0.29), representing a 40 percent increase relative to the mean. Panel B reports consistent results using an indicator for the presence of at least one female director ($\beta_1 = 2.206$, $p < .001$).

We consider several alternative explanations. There may be confounding factors correlated with the Big Three ownership that can lead to different trends in outcomes. First, the observed effects may reflect broader changes in foreign institutional ownership rather than mechanisms specific to the Big Three. Column (2) includes an interaction between non-Big Three foreign ownership and the post-reform indicator to address this concern, and the results remain robust.

Second, firms' gender composition may be linked to Big Three ownership, and firms with no female directors may be more likely to add women over time (Gormley et al., 2023). Column (3) addresses this possibility by interacting the post-reform indicator with an indicator for firms with all-male boards in 2012. The results remain robust.

Third, variation in Big Three ownership is associated with firm characteristics such as size, index inclusion, and board structure. Columns (4)–(10) allow for differential post-reform trends along these dimensions by interacting the post indicator with pre-reform firm characteristics. The interaction effect with Big Three ownership remains stable across these specifications. Column (11) presents a specification including all dimensions simultaneously, with consistent results.

Overall, these findings provide evidence that firms with greater exposure to the Big Three experience larger increases in board gender diversity following the “Womenomics” reforms.⁵

INSERT TABLE IV ABOUT HERE

Dynamic Effects and Parallel Trends

Table V and Figure 2 examine the timing of the effects. We estimate an event study specification that allows the effect of Big Three ownership to vary over time relative to the introduction of the “Womenomics” reforms.

Consistent with the parallel trends assumption, the estimates suggest that the interaction coefficients between Big Three ownership and year indicators for the pre-reform period (2006–2012) are small in magnitude and not statistically different from zero. The pre-treatment coefficients do not exhibit a systematic trend, providing no statistical evidence of differential pre-reform effects by Big Three ownership.

In contrast, the association between Big Three ownership and board gender diversity becomes positive and statistically significant in the post-reform period. The magnitude of the effect increases over time, indicating a sustained divergence between firms with higher and lower exposure to the Big Three.

Figure 2 illustrates that the post-reform increase in gender diversity is gradual rather than abrupt. This pattern is consistent with the time required for board turnover and director appointments, as well as with the incremental nature of governance change in the Japanese context (Mun and Jung, 2018). The slight and insignificant increase in 2011 and 2012 may be explained by smaller-scale gender-related efforts preceding “Womenomics”, including Japan’s 2011 commitment in the High-Level Policy Dialogue on Women and the Economy and the Tokyo Stock Exchange’s introduction of the “Nadeshiko Brand” in 2012. We address the potential pre-trend concerns related to earlier initiatives through the following points.

From the firms’ perspective, in theory, it is difficult for firms to anticipate the major 2013

reform. Early drafts and government discussions are vague and provide no clear requirements or a predictable timeline. Moreover, gender diversity is a low-salience and low-priority governance issue in Japan before the reform, so early small-scale discussions do not trigger significant preparatory actions. In addition, before “Womenomics,” there are no strong precedents on gender diversity, leaving firms without a baseline to guide expectations or planning.

Empirically, even if firms fully anticipate the reform, such anticipation does not drive the estimated effects. Firms may act early to appoint women before the reform, which would mechanically attenuate our estimates. Nevertheless, we continue to observe statistically significant effects after 2013. Firms may also prepare for the reform without making early appointments. While this does not violate the parallel trends assumption, such preparation could correlate with firm characteristics, and thus with Big Three ownership, potentially creating differential post-reform trends. However, as shown in Table IV (Columns (4)–(10)), we control for these factors and find consistent results.

From the Big Three’s perspective, a potential concern is that they might anticipate and adjust their portfolios toward firms likely to increase female representation before 2013. By theory, these investors are unlikely to adjust their portfolios based primarily on female representation, regardless of other firm fundamentals. Even if the Big Three consider female representation as a basis for portfolio decisions, it is difficult for them to predict which firms are likely to increase the number of female directors, with 95 percent of firms in our sample having no female directors in 2012.

Moreover, we regress Big Three ownership on year indicators interacted with the female ratio in 2012. If anticipatory behaviors exist, we expect significant coefficients and clear trends before the reform. However, as shown in Online Appendix Table AII, the pre-2012 coefficients

are small and statistically insignificant, with no clear pattern in their magnitude. We also fail to reject the joint null that they are equal to zero ($F = 0.38$, $p = 0.8245$). These results provide no statistical evidence that the Big Three adjust investment before the reform, mitigating concerns that anticipatory portfolio adjustments drive our findings.

INSERT TABLE V AND FIGURE 2 ABOUT HERE

Modes of Implementation

We next examine how firms increase female representation on their boards. Following Knippen et al. (2019), a more substantial change is captured by director substitution, defined as an increase in the number of female directors without a corresponding increase in board size. In contrast, board expansion is perceived as an easier move, defined as an increase in the number of female directors accompanied by an increase in board size.

Table VI reports the results. Firms with greater Big Three ownership are more likely to increase gender diversity through substitution rather than expansion following the reform. In Column (1), the interaction between Big Three ownership and the post-reform indicator is positive and statistically significant for substitution ($\beta_1 = 0.354$, $p < .001$), indicating that firms with higher Big Three ownership are more likely to replace male directors with female directors. The magnitude of the effect is economically meaningful relative to the baseline rate of substitution. In contrast, Column (2) shows no statistically significant effect on board expansion-based additions of female directors. A statistical test also supports that the effect on substitution is significantly larger than the effect on expansion ($Z = 2.408$, $p = 0.016$).

We complement our analysis by examining whether the Big Three increase firms' pursuit of third-party acknowledgment for their gender diversity practices, capturing a broader legitimacy-seeking response. To do so, we analyze firms' applications to and receipt of the "Nadeshiko

Brand” designation, a government recognition awarded to firms demonstrating outstanding practices in promoting women’s advancement. Columns (3) and (4) show that Big Three ownership is positively associated with both application to and receipt of the designation following the reform ($\beta_1 = 3.308, p < .001$; $\beta_1 = 0.860, p < .001$).

These results indicate that firms with higher Big Three ownership are more likely to change board gender composition in a more substantial manner and to receive public recognition of gender diversity practices.

INSERT TABLE VI ABOUT HERE

Gender Diversity and Governance-Related Scrutiny

We next examine whether firms exposed to investor-driven gender diversity pressure experience changes in governance-related scrutiny. Our analysis spans 2007–2020, starting with the first year of available RepRisk data. We first apply reduced-form specifications. We use the interaction of Big Three ownership and the post-reform period as a plausibly exogenous measure of exposure to the “Womenomics” reform, which prior analyses show increases female board representation. Treatment and control groups are defined as in the baseline specification. We then complement this approach with instrumental variable (IV) specifications that isolate variation in board female representation induced by the reform. We estimate the following specification:

$$Govern\ issues_{it+1} = \beta_1 Big3\ ownership_{it} \times Post2013_t + \beta_2 Big3\ ownership_{it} + \beta_3 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (2)$$

$Govern\ issues_{it+1}$ is an indicator equal to one if firm i is associated with at least one governance-related incident in year $t+1$, and zero otherwise.

Table VII reports the baseline results. In Column (1), the interaction between Big Three ownership and the post-reform indicator is positive and statistically significant ($\beta_1 = 1.801, p$

< .001), indicating that firms with higher Big Three ownership experience an increase in externally reported governance-related incidents following the reform. The magnitude of the effect is economically meaningful relative to the baseline probability of reported incidents. This pattern is robust across alternative specifications that control for potential alternative channels, allowing for differential post-reform trends based on firm characteristics (Columns (2)–(10)).

These results are consistent with, but do not by themselves establish, the interpretation that firms more exposed to investor-driven gender diversity pressure have greater governance-related scrutiny. Importantly, this association does not necessarily indicate deteriorating governance quality, but rather reflects how firms are subject to domestic societal perception.

INSERT TABLE VII ABOUT HERE

Online Appendix S1, Table AVIII further examines the composition of governance-related incidents and shows that the association is not driven by a single category of reported issues. We interpret these results cautiously, as they reflect externally reported incidents rather than verified changes in underlying misconduct.

Additional Analyses: Interpreting Governance-Related Risk Incidents

The observed rise in governance-related incidents could reflect either a genuine deterioration or increased scrutiny without actual deterioration. Although we cannot fully distinguish between these two scenarios, our analysis offers insights into which is more likely.

We first examine in which contexts these incidents are more concentrated. If incidents arise from external scrutiny without underlying deterioration, they should be more common where societal actors are more likely to notice and interpret divergent behavior critically. Highly visible firms and male-dominated industries are natural contexts to test this. More visible firms are easier targets for scrutiny and commentary. In male-dominated industries, gender diversity

changes are more normatively salient and stand out more clearly against historical patterns, which increases the likelihood that they are subject to external debate. In contrast, if incidents stem from actual deterioration behaviors, they should be higher where governance failure is more prevalent, regardless of visibility or industry gender composition.

Table VIII reports results consistent with the absence of actual deterioration. Governance-related incidents are more likely to arise in male-dominated industries and firms with greater visibility, following the reform (Columns (1) – (5)). In contrast, we find no statistical evidence related to this argument among underperforming firms (Columns (6) – (8)).

INSERT TABLE VIII ABOUT HERE

Second, if governance-related incidents reflect underlying deterioration, they should coincide with declines in firm performance, financial reporting quality, or external audit oversight. In contrast, if they reflect interpretive scrutiny, such incidents should not be associated with declines in those measures. As reported in Online Appendix S1, Tables AXIII and AXIV, we find no systematic evidence of declines in performance (e.g., financial performance, managerial outlook, and firm growth), or governance indicators related to financial reporting and external oversight (e.g., restatements, managerial forecast reporting quality, earnings surprises, and audit fees). In addition, these tests suggest that firm performance and financial reporting quality are unlikely to be the main channels driving the reduced-form results, leaving gender diversity as a plausible pathway.

Lastly, we examine whether the characteristics of reported governance incidents change following the reform. As shown in Online Appendix S1 Table AXV, the increase in reported incidents is not driven by greater severity or wider reach (i.e., coverage by more influential information resources), but rather by higher novelty. This pattern suggests that the rise in

incidents reflects previously unreported issues that attract and sustain public attention, rather than a deterioration in realized governance conditions.

Robustness Checks

Robustness checks: Big Three ownership, the reform, and board female representation

First, to address concerns that Big Three ownership may respond to, rather than drive, firms' gender diversity initiatives, we re-estimate our models using pre-reform ownership measured in 2012 (Gormley et al., 2023). The results, reported in Online Appendix S1, Table AIII, remain consistent with our baseline findings. Similar results are obtained using a binary treatment definition based on pre-reform ownership (Online Appendix S1, Table AIV).

Second, we consider whether contemporaneous policy initiatives confound our estimates. In particular, the 2015 Act on Promotion of Women's Participation mandates firms with more than 300 employees to disclose gender-related metrics and action plans. Because firms subject to this requirement are likely to have higher Big Three ownership, observed increases in board gender diversity could reflect compliance with the Act rather than investor pressure. To address this concern, we allow for differential post-2015 trends among affected firms. As reported in Online Appendix S1 Table AV, the interaction between Big Three ownership and the post-reform period remains positive and statistically significant.

A further concern regarding the depth of gender diversity change relates to supply-side constraints in the market for female directors. Given the historically limited pool of women with prior board experience in Japan (Mun and Jung, 2018), firms facing diversity pressure may appoint the same individuals to multiple boards (Gormley et al., 2023). We examine whether increased Big Three ownership is associated with a rise in the number of board seats held by female directors after the reform and find no evidence of increased cross-board appointments

among female directors (Online Appendix S1, Table AVI). This pattern suggests that firms expand the pool of female directors rather than concentrating appointments among a limited set of individuals.

Robustness checks: Gender diversity and governance-related scrutiny

We estimate a two-stage least squares (2SLS) model in which female board representation is instrumented by the interaction between Big Three ownership and the post-reform period, and governance-related incidents are regressed on the instrumented female representation. This approach isolates the variation in female board representation that is driven by exposure to the “Womenomics” reform. The first-stage F-statistic exceeds the conventional threshold of 10, indicating the relevance of the instrument. The second stage results, reported in Online Appendix S1, Tables AXI and AXII, are consistent with our main findings.

Finally, we re-estimate the scrutiny models using pre-reform ownership measured in 2012. The results, reported in Online Appendix S1, Table AIX, remain consistent with the baseline findings, suggesting that the observed association is unlikely to be driven by post-reform adjustments in Big Three ownership.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

This study examines how globally promoted governance practices are adopted and interpreted in institutional contexts where global governance expectations are not fully aligned with locally embedded governance norms. Focusing on the introduction of the “Womenomics” reforms in Japan, we show that firms with greater ownership by the Big Three institutional investors exhibit larger increases in board gender diversity following the reform. These changes are more likely to involve restructuring existing board composition rather than expanding board size. At the same time, firms more exposed to investor-induced increases in board gender

diversity experience increases in externally reported governance-related incidents, particularly among more visible firms and in industries where gender diversity is less pronounced. These findings show that global investor pressure and local institutional conditions jointly shape organizational change and how that change is subsequently evaluated by external audiences.

Our findings contribute to research on corporate governance and institutional environments by demonstrating that the effects of large institutional investors depend on the contexts in which their governance expectations are implemented. Prior work shows that the Big Three influence governance through standardized stewardship practices applied across diversified portfolios (Appel et al., 2016; Dyck et al., 2019; Azar et al., 2021; Gormley et al., 2023). We extend this literature by showing that institutional conditions influence not only whether investor pressure translates into organizational change, but also how governance changes are interpreted once implemented. While prior research has largely focused on the diffusion of governance practices, our findings suggest that the consequences of those practices depend on the institutional environments in which they are evaluated. Governance changes promoted by global investors may therefore generate different reactions across contexts even when firms adopt similar practices, extending recent research on contested governance reforms in East Asian institutional settings (Chung, Luo and Zheng, 2024).

The study also advances research on organizational responses to institutional pressures by showing that external investor pressure can shape not only whether firms adopt governance practices, but also how governance structures are reconfigured in response. Firms with greater exposure to the Big Three are more likely to increase board gender diversity through director replacement rather than through board expansion. These findings suggest that sustained and standardized investor pressure influences not only whether firms respond to governance

expectations, but also how governance changes are implemented, with more exposed firms adopting more consequential adjustments to existing governance structures. This complements recent work on the governance consequences of gender diversity reforms (Duran et al., 2025).

More broadly, our findings contribute to research on organizational assessment by showing that governance practices may be evaluated differently across institutional environments, even when firms adopt similar governance changes. Governance practices promoted as desirable by global investors do not necessarily carry the same meaning across institutional environments, consistent with arguments that organizational practices acquire different meanings and consequences across contexts (Winkler and Krzeminska, 2024). In our setting, investor-induced increases in board gender diversity were associated with heightened governance-related scrutiny despite no systematic evidence of deteriorating governance quality. These findings suggest that governance convergence does not necessarily imply interpretive convergence, consistent with recent work emphasizing that legitimacy and evaluation may vary across institutional environments and audiences (Jones and Murray, 2026).

Taken together, these findings suggest that the consequences of governance changes cannot be understood solely in terms of adoption or adjustment. While global investors promote convergence toward widely endorsed governance standards, the reception of these practices depends on how they are interpreted in specific institutional contexts. This underscores that governance convergence may generate organizational change without generating convergence in how those changes are interpreted across audiences.

These insights also have implications for research on global governance and diversity and respond to recent calls for greater engagement with non-Western institutional contexts in management scholarship (Wickert et al., 2024). A growing literature examines how governance

practices diffuse across firms and countries. Our results suggest that diffusion alone does not determine outcomes. While our setting is distinctive, the underlying mechanism, i.e., misalignment between globally promoted practices and local norms, may extend to other contexts where governance practices diffuse across heterogeneous institutional environments. The consequences of globally promoted governance practices depend on how they interact with local institutional environments. In contexts where gender diversity remains unevenly institutionalized, governance changes towards a global standard may increase visibility and scrutiny without generating uniformly favorable interpretations across audiences.

This study has several limitations that suggest directions for future research. First, our measure of externally reported governance-related incidents captures variation in publicly visible scrutiny, but does not allow us to disentangle underlying misconduct from variation in reporting intensity. Future research could build on this approach by examining how governance-related incidents are reported across different types of media and stakeholders. Second, our empirical setting focuses on Japan, where gender diversity has historically been limited, and reforms have been largely non-binding. While this context allows us to examine how governance changes are interpreted under conditions of incomplete alignment, future work could explore whether similar dynamics arise in settings with stronger regulatory mandates or more established norms. Third, while our findings are consistent with increased external attention and scrutiny following governance changes, further research could examine how specific intermediaries contribute to this process and how firms respond to heightened scrutiny over time.

In conclusion, this study shows that governance changes do more than alter organizational practices; they also shape the conditions under which those changes are perceived and interpreted. While global investors can promote substantial changes in corporate governance,

these changes may also increase firms' exposure to governance-related scrutiny, particularly in contexts where audiences apply different criteria. Understanding this dual effect is critical for assessing the broader implications of governance convergence across institutional environments.

NOTES

¹ We focus on board gender diversity for three reasons. First, it is a highly visible aspect of governance and often the first area affected by change (Mun & Jung, 2018). Second, boards are the primary decision-making and oversight bodies, so diversity at this level directly affects governance quality and strategic direction. Third, board composition is a key item in public reporting under the reform, providing reliable data and reducing measurement error and selection bias.

² Large language model-based artificial intelligence tools were used exclusively to assist with limited drafting and language editing of the manuscript text. No scientific content, data analysis, interpretation, or conclusions were generated by the tool. All content was reviewed and approved by the authors.

³ We retain the full sample of incidents in all analyses, even though 14 percent of governance-related risk incidents come from high-reach global outlets. This is because some high-reach source incidents may be from the global media Japanese divisions. Excluding them may introduce bias or create the appearance of selective reporting consistent with our theory. Nevertheless, our baseline results remain robust when the outcome variable is set to 1 only for limited- and medium-reach incidents. The results are shown in Online Appendix S1 Table AX.

⁴ We use OLS regression, including when the dependent variable is binary, consistent with standard practice in difference-in-differences designs with panel data. In short panels, the fixed-effects Logit model is subject to the incidental parameters problem and yields inconsistent estimates. This concern is particularly salient in our setting, given the potential serial correlation of the dependent variable, which further exacerbates bias in nonlinear fixed-effects estimators. Hence, in this setting, OLS yields consistent estimates of average treatment effects under the

parallel-trends and strict-exogeneity assumptions. OLS also facilitates straightforward adjustment of standard errors for within-firm serial correlation through clustering.

⁵ The results are robust when the controls' interactions are specified with year dummies.

REFERENCE

- Abe, S. (2013). 'Unleashing the power of "Womenomics"'. *Wall Street Journal*, September 25.
<https://www.wsj.com/articles/SB10001424052702303759604579091680931293404>
- Aggarwal, R., Erel, I., Ferreira, M., & Matos, P. (2011). Does governance travel around the world? Evidence from institutional investors. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 100(1), 154–181.
- Aguilera, R. V., Desender, K. A., & Lopez-Puertas-Lamy, M. (2025). From universal owners to owners of the universe? How the Big Three are reshaping corporate governance. *Corporate Governance: An International Review*, 33(3), 462–482.
- Aguilera, R. V., & Jackson, G. (2003). The cross-national diversity of corporate governance: Dimensions and determinants. *Academy of management Review*, 28(3), 447-465.
- Ahmadjian, C. L., & Robinson, P. (2001). Safety in numbers: Downsizing and the deinstitutionalization of permanent employment in Japan. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 46(4), 622–654.
- Aoki, M. (2001). *Toward a comparative institutional analysis*. MIT press.
- Appel, I. R., Gormley, T. A., & Keim, D. B. (2016). Passive investors, not passive owners. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 121(1), 111–141.
- Azar, J., Duro, M., Kadach, I., & Ormazabal, G. (2021). The Big Three and corporate carbon emissions around the world. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 142(2), 674–696.
- Bednar, M. K. (2012). Watchdog or lapdog? A behavioral view of the media as a corporate governance mechanism. *Academy of Management Journal*, 55(1), 131–150.
- Bednar, M. K., Boivie, S., & Prince, N. R. (2013). Burr under the saddle: How media coverage influences strategic change. *Organization Science*, 24(3), 910–925.

- Brinton, M. C. (2023). *Women and the economic miracle: Gender and work in postwar Japan*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.
- Castilla, E. J., & S. Benard. (2010). The paradox of meritocracy in organizations. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 55(4), 543–676.
- Chung, C.-N., Luo, X. R., & Zheng, W. (2024). Institutional divide, political ties, and contested corporate governance reform in Taiwan. *Journal of Management Studies*, 61(4), 1327–1363.
- Cohen, S., Kadach, I., & Ormazabal, G. (2023). Institutional investors, climate disclosure, and carbon emissions. *Journal of Accounting and Economics*, 76(2-3), 101640.
- Cohen, S., Kadach, I., Ormazabal, G., & Reichelstein, S. (2023). Executive compensation tied to ESG performance: International evidence. *Journal of Accounting Research*, 61(3), 805-853.
- Deephouse, D. L. (2000). Media reputation as a strategic resource: An integration of mass communication and resource-based theories. *Journal of Management*, 26(6), 1091–1112.
- Deephouse, D. L., & Suchman, M. (2008). Legitimacy in organizational institutionalism. *The Sage handbook of organizational institutionalism*, 49(77), 273-289.
- Desender, K. A., Aguilera, R. V., Lópezpuertas-Lamy, M., & Crespi, R. (2016). A clash of governance logics: Foreign ownership and board monitoring. *Strategic Management Journal*, 37(2), 349-369.
- DesJardine, M. R., Grewal, J., & Viswanathan, K. (2023). A rising tide lifts all boats: The effects of common ownership on corporate social responsibility. *Organization Science*, 34(5), 1716–1735.
- Dobbin, F., & A. Kalev. (2016). Why diversity programs fail. *Harvard Business Review* 94(7–8), 52–60.

- Duran, P., Heugens, P. P. M. A. R., Aguinis, H., Cook, A., & de Villiers, C. (2025). Leave the token, take the gavel: How national quotas and ownership structures shape women's influence on major board committees. *Journal of Management Studies* (Early View).
- Durand, R., Hawn, O., & Ioannou, I. (2019). Willing and able: A general model of organizational responses to normative pressures. *Academy of Management Review*, 44(2), 299–320.
- Dyck, A., Lins, K. V., Roth, L., & Wagner, H. F. (2019). Do institutional investors drive corporate social responsibility? International evidence. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 131(3), 693–714.
- Dyck, A., Volchkova, N., & Zingales, L. (2008). The corporate governance role of the media: Evidence from Russia. *Journal of Finance*, 63(3), 1093–1135.
- Eagly, A. H., & Karau, S. J. (2002). Role congruity theory of prejudice toward female leaders. *Psychological Review*, 109(3), 573–598.
- Edmans, A., Levit, D., & Reilly, D. (2019). Governance under common ownership. *Review of Financial Studies*, 32(7), 2673–2719.
- Eesley, C., & Lenox, M. J. (2006). Firm responses to secondary stakeholder action. *Strategic Management Journal*, 27(8), 765–781.
- Gilson, R. J., & Roe, M. J. (1999). Lifetime employment: Labor peace and the evolution of Japanese corporate governance. *Columbia Law Review*, 99: 508–540.
- Gormley, T. A., Gupta, V. K., Matsa, D. A., Mortal, S. C., & Yang, L. (2023). The Big Three and board gender diversity: The effectiveness of shareholder voice. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 149(2), 323–348.

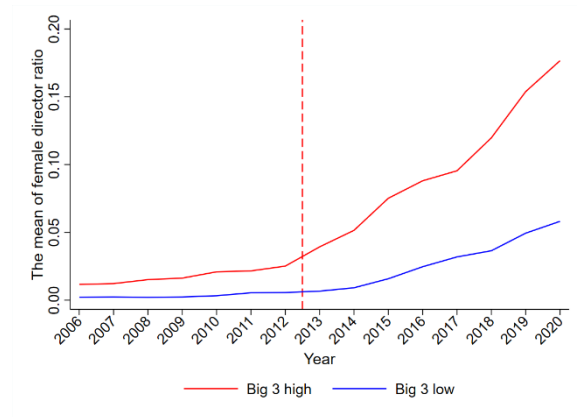
- Government of Japan. (2014). Womenomics is pushing Abenomics forward. Available at: https://www.japan.go.jp/tomodachi/2014/summer2014/womenomics_is_pushing_abenomics_forward.html.
- Ilhan, E., Krueger, P., Sautner, Z., & Starks, L. T. (2023). Climate risk disclosure and institutional investors. *Review of Financial Studies*, 36(7), 2617-2650.
- Japan Cabinet Office. (2013). *Basic policies for economic and fiscal management and reform*. Available at: https://www5.cao.go.jp/keizai1/2013/20130614_2013_basicpolicies_e.pdf.
- Jones, J., & Murray, A. (2026). Contending with perceived legitimacy tensions: Impact investing in pluralistic institutional environments. *Journal of Management Studies*, 63(1), 232–269.
- Kahan, M., & Rock, E. B. (2020). Index funds and corporate governance: Let shareholders be shareholders. *Boston University Law Review*, 100: 1771–1815.
- Kalev, A., F. Dobbin, & E. Kelly. (2006). Best practices or best guesses? Assessing the efficacy of corporate affirmative action and diversity policies. *American Sociological Review* 71(4), 589–617.
- Kennedy, M. T. (2008). Getting counted: Markets, media, and reality. *American Sociological Review*, 73(2), 270–295.
- Knippen, J. M., Shen, W., & Zhu, Q. (2019). Limited progress? The effect of external pressure for board gender diversity on the increase of female directors. *Strategic Management Journal*, 40(7), 1123–1150.
- Meyer, J. W., & B. Rowan. (1977). Institutionalized organizations: Formal structure as myth and ceremony. *American Journal of Sociology* 83(2), 340–363.
- Mun, E., & Jung, J. (2018). Change above the glass ceiling: Corporate social responsibility and gender diversity in Japanese firms. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 63(2), 409–440.

- Nemoto, K. (2013). Long working hours and the corporate gender divide in Japan. *Gender, work & organization*, 20(5), 512-527.
- Oliver, C. (1991). Strategic responses to institutional processes. *Academy of Management Review*, 16(1), 145–179.
- Phillips, N., Lawrence, T. B., & Hardy, C. (2004). Discourse and institutions. *Academy of Management Review*, 29(4), 635-652.
- Schiehl, E., Martins, H. C., & Lewellyn, K. B. (2025). Competing Voices, Persistent Gaps: Shareholder Proposal Activism and ESG Decoupling. *Business & Society*, 65(6), 1643–1681.
- Suchman, M. C. (1995). Managing legitimacy: Strategic and institutional approaches. *Academy of Management Review*, 20(3), 571–610.
- Uchida, D. (2023). The wheel comes full circle? An integrated view of organizational responses to institutional pressures. *Journal of management*, 49(2), 771-807.
- Westphal, J. D., & Zajac, E. J. (1994). Substance and Symbolism in CEOs' Long-Term Incentive Plans. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 39(3), 367–390.
- Wickert, C., Potočník, K., Prashantham, S., Shi, W., & Snihur, Y. (2024). Embracing non-Western contexts in management scholarship. *Journal of Management Studies*, 61(8), e1-e24.
- Winkler, D. M., & Krzeminska, A. (2024). How context matters in non-market strategies: Exploring variations in corporate social responsibility-political activity relationships. *Journal of Management Studies*, 61(7), 3358-3388.
- Witt, M. A., Fainshmidt, S., & Aguilera, R. V. (2022). Our board, our rules: Nonconformity to global corporate governance norms. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 67(1), 131-166.

Wu, W., Wang, H., Tong, L., & Zhang, Y. (2025). Tailored adaptation: Aligning social issue engagement with types of legitimacy challenges. *Strategic Management Journal*, 46(8), 1947-1972.

FIGURE 1 The trend of gender diversity on the board divided by the Big Three ownership level
This figure plots the mean value of the female director ratio (Panel A) and the female director dummy (Panel B) on the board from 2006 to 2020, divided by the Big Three ownership level. Definitions of all variables are provided in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

Panel A. The trend of female director ratio



Panel B. The trend of female director dummy

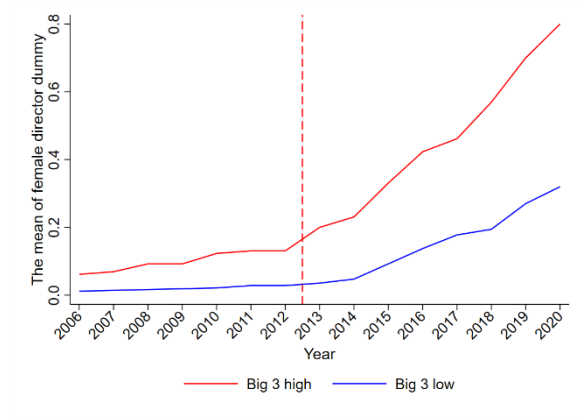
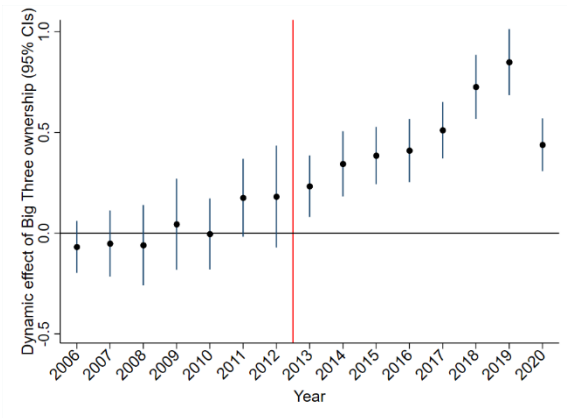


FIGURE 2 Dynamic effects of Big Three shareholdings on gender diversity

This figure plots the marginal effects for each one-unit change in Big Three ownership on the female director ratio (Panel A) and the female director dummy (Panel B) on the board from 2006 to 2020. Vertical bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Robust standard errors are clustered at the firm level. Estimation by OLS regression. Definitions of all variables are provided in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

Panel A. Dynamic effects on female director ratio



Panel B. Dynamic effects on female director dummy

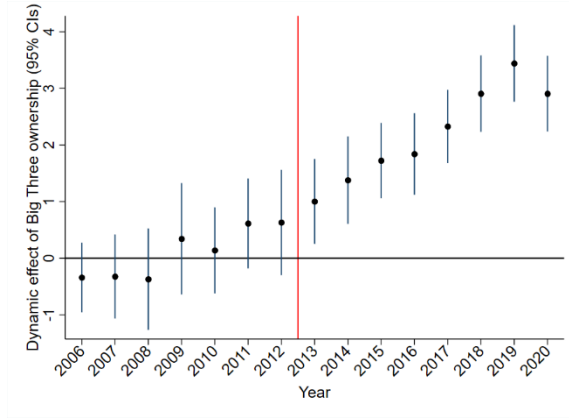


TABLE I Sample construction

Observations with non-missing continuous values from 2006 to 2020	15570
Observations in the financial industries	(1641)
Observations with missing value of corporate governance variables, ownership variables and, financial variables	(804)
Observations with firms switched between treated and control groups during 2012 - 2020	(4845)
Total firm-year observations	8280

TABLE II Summary statistics

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max	p25	p50	p75
Female ratio	8280	0.032	0.077	0.000	0.375	0.000	0.000	0.000
Female dummy	8280	0.175	0.380	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Female zero ²⁰¹²	8280	0.947	0.223	0.000	1.000	1.000	1.000	1.000
Female director seats	1269	1.399	1.518	0.000	6.000	0.000	1.000	2.000
Substitute	8280	0.038	0.190	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Add	8280	0.011	0.105	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Nadeshiko apply	8280	0.095	0.294	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Nadeshiko win	8280	0.018	0.134	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Big3 ownership	8280	0.023	0.043	0.000	0.209	0.000	0.000	0.028
Big3 ownership ²⁰¹²	8280	0.012	0.026	0.000	0.134	0.000	0.000	0.000
Big3 ownership (high)	1950	0.078	0.057	0.000	0.209	0.033	0.067	0.115
Big3 ownership (low)	6330	0.006	0.015	0.000	0.209	0.000	0.000	0.000
Non-Big3 foreign ownership	8280	0.108	0.134	0.000	0.652	0.016	0.055	0.151
Sales ²⁰¹²	8280	20.907	1.538	17.987	24.623	19.770	20.675	21.906
Market capitalization ²⁰¹²	8280	19.938	1.697	17.091	24.212	18.670	19.527	21.202
Assets ²⁰¹²	8280	20.972	1.551	18.095	24.946	19.846	20.619	21.976
MSCI ²⁰¹²	8280	0.042	0.200	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
S&P1200 ²⁰¹²	8280	0.132	0.339	0.000	1.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Board independence ²⁰¹²	8280	0.113	0.142	0.000	0.556	0.000	0.071	0.182
Board size ²⁰¹²	8280	8.734	3.156	4.000	19.000	6.000	8.000	10.000
Domestic concentration	8280	0.171	0.158	0.014	0.800	0.075	0.115	0.203
Domestic bank ownership	8280	0.134	0.122	0.000	0.484	0.025	0.109	0.212
Domestic corporation ownership	8280	0.439	0.265	0.000	0.963	0.215	0.432	0.649
Domestic employee ownership	8280	0.028	0.044	0.000	0.206	0.000	0.000	0.048
Cross ownership	8280	0.013	0.026	0.000	0.144	0.000	0.000	0.015

TABLE III Pre-Reform Comparison (2012)

	Sample average by Big3 ownership ²⁰¹²		p-value
	Big3 ownership ²⁰¹² high	Big3 ownership ²⁰¹² low	
Market capitalization ²⁰¹²	22.345	19.200	0.00
Sales ²⁰¹²	22.934	20.279	0.00
Assets ²⁰¹²	23.149	20.301	0.00
MSCI ²⁰¹²	0.146	0.009	0.00
S&P1200 ²⁰¹²	0.562	0.000	0.00
Board size ²⁰¹²	10.738	8.133	0.00
Board independence ²⁰¹²	0.205	0.085	0.00
N	130	422	

This table presents sample averages for the following firm characteristics in 2012 by Big Three ownership high and low groups based on mean value: Market capitalization, sales, assets, MSCI index inclusion, S&P1200 index inclusion, board size, and board independence. The first two columns present sample averages for firms in the high and low Big Three ownership, respectively. The last column provides the p-value from a t-test of the difference in means between the high and low groups. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE IV Baseline Estimates of Board Gender Diversity

Panel A: Female ratio											
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)
Big3 ownership	0.027 (0.076)	0.023 (0.077)	0.029 (0.077)	0.066 (0.075)	0.071 (0.075)	0.068 (0.075)	0.029 (0.073)	0.045 (0.082)	0.026 (0.076)	0.043 (0.075)	0.075 (0.072)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.486*** (0.085)	0.470*** (0.086)	0.473*** (0.087)	0.252** (0.100)	0.274*** (0.093)	0.278*** (0.099)	0.470*** (0.081)	0.429*** (0.112)	0.503*** (0.089)	0.435*** (0.083)	0.215** (0.098)
Domestic Concentration	0.010 (0.020)	0.006 (0.019)	0.009 (0.019)	0.003 (0.019)	0.005 (0.019)	0.003 (0.019)	0.009 (0.019)	0.010 (0.020)	0.012 (0.020)	0.011 (0.019)	0.003 (0.018)
Domestic bank ownership	0.000 (0.019)	-0.005 (0.020)	0.000 (0.019)	-0.003 (0.019)	0.002 (0.019)	0.003 (0.019)	0.000 (0.019)	0.001 (0.019)	-0.000 (0.019)	-0.003 (0.019)	-0.010 (0.019)
Domestic corporate ownership	-0.008 (0.009)	-0.010 (0.009)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.004 (0.009)	-0.002 (0.009)	-0.001 (0.009)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.009 (0.009)	-0.009 (0.009)	-0.007 (0.009)
Domestic employee ownership	-0.018 (0.044)	-0.023 (0.044)	-0.018 (0.044)	-0.010 (0.044)	-0.018 (0.044)	-0.016 (0.044)	-0.016 (0.044)	-0.016 (0.044)	-0.017 (0.044)	-0.024 (0.044)	-0.013 (0.044)
Cross ownership	0.017 (0.109)	0.012 (0.108)	0.016 (0.108)	0.008 (0.103)	0.013 (0.109)	0.005 (0.110)	0.006 (0.104)	0.020 (0.109)	0.017 (0.108)	0.030 (0.109)	0.006 (0.100)
Non-Big3 foreign ownership	0.010 (0.017)		0.011 (0.017)	0.008 (0.017)	0.008 (0.017)	0.011 (0.017)	0.010 (0.017)	0.011 (0.017)	0.010 (0.017)	0.010 (0.017)	
Non – Big3 ownership ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013		0.011 (0.023)									-0.014 (0.026)
Female zero ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013			-0.011 (0.017)								-0.003 (0.018)
Market capitalization ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013				0.009*** (0.002)							0.011*** (0.003)
Sales ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013					0.009*** (0.002)						
Assets ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013						0.008*** (0.002)					
MSCI ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013							0.019 (0.018)				0.009 (0.018)
S&P1200 ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013								0.011 (0.013)			
Board size ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013									-0.001 (0.001)		-0.002*** (0.001)
Board independence ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013										0.048** (0.021)	0.034 (0.021)
Constant	0.023*** (0.007)	0.027*** (0.005)	0.029** (0.012)	-0.068*** (0.024)	-0.079*** (0.026)	-0.071** (0.028)	0.023*** (0.007)	0.023*** (0.007)	0.027*** (0.008)	0.022*** (0.007)	-0.074*** (0.028)
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280
Adjusted R ²	0.560	0.560	0.560	0.564	0.564	0.563	0.560	0.560	0.560	0.562	0.567
Panel B: Female dummy											
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)
Big3 ownership	0.103 (0.294)	0.105 (0.291)	0.076 (0.293)	0.263 (0.293)	0.260 (0.295)	0.263 (0.298)	0.110 (0.289)	0.122 (0.310)	0.106 (0.294)	0.125 (0.294)	0.261 (0.289)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	2.206***	2.123***	2.308***	1.234***	1.451***	1.399***	2.157***	2.145***	2.164***	2.135***	1.225***

	(0.337)	(0.350)	(0.336)	(0.444)	(0.417)	(0.446)	(0.337)	(0.436)	(0.353)	(0.341)	(0.438)
Domestic Concentration	-0.021	-0.032	-0.008	-0.050	-0.041	-0.049	-0.025	-0.021	-0.025	-0.020	-0.036
	(0.096)	(0.090)	(0.096)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.096)	(0.096)	(0.096)	(0.096)	(0.090)
Domestic bank ownership	-0.008	-0.029	-0.004	-0.022	0.000	0.002	-0.007	-0.007	-0.007	-0.013	-0.030
	(0.095)	(0.092)	(0.094)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.095)	(0.091)
Domestic corporate ownership	-0.092*	-0.098**	-0.099*	-0.076	-0.070	-0.067	-0.090*	-0.091*	-0.090*	-0.094*	-0.088*
	(0.051)	(0.048)	(0.051)	(0.051)	(0.052)	(0.052)	(0.051)	(0.051)	(0.051)	(0.051)	(0.048)
Domestic employee ownership	-0.060	-0.078	-0.078	-0.029	-0.060	-0.053	-0.054	-0.058	-0.062	-0.069	-0.051
	(0.260)	(0.259)	(0.258)	(0.261)	(0.261)	(0.261)	(0.258)	(0.260)	(0.259)	(0.261)	(0.261)
Cross ownership	0.446	0.439	0.461	0.411	0.432	0.399	0.414	0.449	0.446	0.465	0.430
	(0.587)	(0.588)	(0.602)	(0.555)	(0.587)	(0.584)	(0.577)	(0.587)	(0.587)	(0.587)	(0.569)
Non-Big3 foreign ownership	0.028		0.021	0.020	0.022	0.031	0.028	0.030	0.028	0.028	
	(0.079)		(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.079)	
Non – Big3 ownership ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013		0.078									0.006
		(0.103)									(0.110)
Female zero ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013			0.108*								0.135**
			(0.061)								(0.064)
Market capitalization ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013				0.037***							0.042***
				(0.011)							(0.012)
Sales ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013					0.033***						
					(0.011)						
Assets ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013						0.033***					
						(0.012)					
MSCI ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013							0.058				0.012
							(0.073)				(0.073)
S&P1200 ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013								0.012			
								(0.051)			
Board size ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013									0.002		-0.004
									(0.004)		(0.005)
Board independence ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013										0.068	0.056
										(0.091)	(0.090)
Constant	0.171***	0.180***	0.117**	-0.209*	-0.193	-0.194	0.170***	0.170***	0.162***	0.169***	-0.312**
	(0.038)	(0.027)	(0.048)	(0.117)	(0.128)	(0.136)	(0.038)	(0.038)	(0.041)	(0.038)	(0.129)
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280
Adjusted R ²	0.551	0.551	0.551	0.554	0.553	0.553	0.551	0.551	0.551	0.551	0.555

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of female board representation on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are the female ratio on the board (Panel A), and whether there are females on the board (Panel B). Column (2) includes a control for Non-Big Three foreign ownership in 2012 interacted with Post 2013. Column (3) includes a control for no female director indicator in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (4) includes a control for log market cap in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (5) includes a control for log assets in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (6) includes a control for log sales in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (7) includes a control for MSCI Index inclusion in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (8) includes a control for S&P 1200 Index inclusion in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (9) includes a control for board size in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (10) includes a control for board independence in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (11) includes controls for the Non-Big Three ownership, no-female-director indicator, log market capitalization, MSCI Index inclusion, board size, and board independence, with their 2012 values interacted with the Post-2013 indicator. The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE V Dynamic Effects and Parallel Trends

Dependent variable	(1) Female ratio	(2) Female dummy
Big3 ownership×Year = 2006	-0.068 (0.066)	-0.340 (0.313)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2007	-0.050 (0.083)	-0.323 (0.378)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2008	-0.059 (0.102)	-0.370 (0.456)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2009	0.046 (0.115)	0.342 (0.501)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2010	-0.003 (0.090)	0.138 (0.387)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2011	0.176* (0.099)	0.613 (0.404)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2012	0.181 (0.129)	0.630 (0.473)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2013	0.233*** (0.078)	1.002*** (0.382)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2014	0.344*** (0.082)	1.379*** (0.393)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2015	0.385*** (0.072)	1.724*** (0.338)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2016	0.410*** (0.080)	1.841*** (0.367)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2017	0.512*** (0.071)	2.329*** (0.329)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2018	0.727*** (0.081)	2.908*** (0.343)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2019	0.850*** (0.084)	3.443*** (0.345)
Big3 ownership×Year = 2020	0.462*** (0.068)	2.882*** (0.339)
Constant	0.020*** (0.007)	0.148*** (0.037)
Controls	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8280	8280
Adjusted <i>R</i> ²	0.567	0.556

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of female board representation on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and indicators for each year from 2006 through 2020. The dependent variables are the female ratio on the board (Column (1)), and whether there are females on the board (Column (2)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE VI Degree of Gender Diversity Changes

Dependent variable	(1) Substitution	(2) Addition	(3) Nadeshiko apply	(4) Nadeshiko win
Big3 ownership	-0.001 (0.122)	-0.003 (0.058)	-0.972*** (0.266)	-0.293 (0.191)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.364*** (0.131)	0.004 (0.060)	3.308*** (0.320)	0.860*** (0.187)
Constant	0.042*** (0.016)	0.012 (0.008)	0.073*** (0.026)	0.007 (0.013)
Z-statistic	2.408			
p-value	0.016			
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8280	8280	8280	8280
Adjusted <i>R</i> ²	0.039	0.013	0.408	0.247

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of substituting or adding female directors on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are whether the females are appointed through substitution (Column (1)), whether females are appointed through extra addition (Column (2)), whether firms apply for the “Nadeshiko brand” (Column (3)), and whether firms are listed on the “Nadeshiko brand” (Column (4)). Z-statistic and p-value correspond to a z-test comparing the coefficients on the interaction terms in Columns (1) and (2). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE VII Governance-Related Risk Incidents (Baseline Results)

Dependent variable	(1) Governanc e issues	(2) Governanc e issues	(3) Governanc e issues	(4) Governanc e issues	(5) Governanc e issues	(6) Governanc e issues	(7) Governanc e issues	(8) Governanc e issues	(9) Governanc e issues	(10) Governanc e issues
Big3 ownership	-0.209 (0.274)	-0.200 (0.273)	-0.101 (0.268)	-0.037 (0.264)	-0.023 (0.264)	-0.202 (0.275)	-0.016 (0.272)	-0.206 (0.273)	-0.167 (0.272)	-0.070 (0.269)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	1.801*** (0.253)	1.770*** (0.255)	1.143*** (0.301)	0.973*** (0.271)	0.860*** (0.288)	1.753*** (0.258)	1.175*** (0.305)	1.759*** (0.262)	1.667*** (0.255)	1.062*** (0.303)
Female zero ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013		-0.034 (0.028)								-0.012 (0.029)
Market capitalization ²⁰¹² × Post2013			0.025*** (0.006)							0.024*** (0.007)
Sales ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013				0.036*** (0.006)						
Assets ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013					0.038*** (0.007)					
MSCI ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013						0.055 (0.053)				0.034 (0.052)
S&P1200 ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013							0.124*** (0.034)			
Board size ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013								0.002 (0.002)		-0.001 (0.002)
Board independence ²⁰¹² × Post 2013									0.128*** (0.044)	0.096** (0.043)
Constant	0.080*** (0.022)	0.097*** (0.024)	-0.177*** (0.066)	-0.319*** (0.069)	-0.345*** (0.077)	0.079*** (0.022)	0.071*** (0.022)	0.071*** (0.023)	0.076*** (0.022)	-0.157** (0.073)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265
Adjusted R ²	0.413	0.413	0.416	0.419	0.419	0.414	0.417	0.413	0.414	0.417

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of governance risk incidents on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variable is whether there are governance risk incidents. Columns (2) include a control for no female director indicator in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (3) includes a control for log market cap in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (4) includes a control for log assets in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (5) includes a control for log sales in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (6) includes a control for MSCI Index inclusion in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (7) includes a control for S&P 1200 Index inclusion in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (8) includes a control for board size in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (9) includes a control for board independence in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (10) includes controls for the no-female-director indicator, log market capitalization, MSCI Index inclusion, board size, and board independence, with their 2012 values interacted with the Post-2013 indicator. The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE VIII Governance Scrutiny: Industry and Visibility Effects

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Dependent variable	Governance issue	Governance issue	Governance issue	Governance issue	Governance issue	Governance issue	Governance issue	Governance issue
Contingent factor	No female director industry	Market capitalization	Sales	Assets	Employee number	ROE shortfall	ROA shortfall	Tobin's Q shortfall
Big3 ownership	-0.120 (0.264)	0.153 (2.505)	-2.081 (3.076)	-2.163 (3.084)	-0.189 (1.078)	-0.735** (0.341)	-0.820** (0.346)	-0.014 (0.445)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	1.598***	-6.635**	-13.287***	-9.981***	-3.043**	1.902***	1.921***	1.783***
Big3 ownership × Contingent factor ²⁰¹²	(0.244) -1.830	(2.764) -0.009	(3.273) 0.096	(3.219) 0.099	(1.209) 0.016	(0.317) 1.294**	(0.331) 1.398***	(0.350) -0.398
Post 2013 × Contingent factor ²⁰¹²	(1.248) -0.028	(0.126) 0.020***	(0.147) 0.024***	(0.146) 0.030***	(0.138) 0.024***	(0.518) 0.004	(0.510) -0.001	(0.534) -0.002
Big3 ownership×Post 2013 × Contingent factor ²⁰¹²	(0.017) 2.759***	(0.006) 0.350***	(0.006) 0.619***	(0.007) 0.465***	(0.006) 0.437***	(0.011) -0.288	(0.010) -0.345	(0.012) -0.079
Constant	(0.985) 0.083*** (0.022)	(0.130) -0.126* (0.066)	(0.150) -0.198*** (0.070)	(0.147) -0.256*** (0.079)	(0.142) -0.019 (0.033)	(0.485) 0.082*** (0.021)	(0.474) 0.083*** (0.021)	(0.521) 0.080*** (0.022)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8265	8265	8265	8265	7725	8265	8265	8265
Adjusted R ²	0.416	0.418	0.426	0.423	0.430	0.416	0.416	0.414

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of governance risk incidents on interactions between a firm's Big Three ownership, an indicator for years in and after 2013, and a contingent factor. The contingent factors are measured using 2012 data, and include industry with no females (Column (1)), market capitalization (Column (2)), sales (Column (3)), assets (Column (4)), employee number (Column (5)), ROE shortfall (Column (6)), ROA shortfall (Column (7)), and Tobin's Q shortfall (Column (8)). The dependent variable is whether there are governance risk incidents. The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

ONLINE APPENDIX S1. ADDITIONAL ANALYSES

A. Overview of Online Appendix Structure

This appendix provides additional analyses that support the identification strategy, robustness of the main findings, and interpretation of the results. The appendix is organized to parallel the structure of the main analysis, moving from identification and treatment validity to mechanism extensions, robustness and characterization of externally reported governance-related incidents, and tests that inform the interpretation of these incidents.

We begin by describing variable construction and data sources. Table AI provides detailed definitions of all variables used in the analysis, including dependent variables, key independent variables, and control variables.

We next present additional analyses that support the identification strategy underlying the difference-in-differences design. Figure A1 presents the marginal effects of Big Three ownership on governance-related risk incidents after reform, contingent on industry female composition, visibility, and underperformance. Table AII reports results by regressing Big Three ownership on year indicators interacted with the female ratio in 2012, addressing concerns that Big Three adjust their portfolios toward firms expected to increase female representation before 2013. Table AIII re-estimates the main results using pre-reform Big Three ownership measured in 2012, addressing concerns that ownership may respond endogenously to changes in board gender diversity. Table AIV reports results using a binary treatment definition based on whether firms' Big Three ownership exceeds the industry-year mean, demonstrating that the findings are not sensitive to the functional form of the ownership measure. Table AV examines robustness to the 2015 Act on Promotion of Women's Participation by allowing for differential trends among firms subject to disclosure requirements, ensuring that the estimated effects are not driven by contemporaneous policy changes.

We then provide additional evidence related to the mechanisms underlying changes in board composition. Table AVI examines whether firms respond to gender diversity pressure by appointing the same female directors across multiple boards, which would be consistent with supply constraints in the market for female directors. The results show no systematic increase in cross-board appointments, suggesting that firms expand the pool of female directors rather than concentrating appointments among a limited set of individuals.

The next set of analyses focuses on the robustness of externally reported governance-related incidents and their composition. Table AVII shows the distribution of governance-related incidents by the reach of the information source, providing evidence that the majority of the governance-related incidents have a domestic information source. Table AVIII examines the composition of governance-related incidents across issue categories, demonstrating that the results are not driven by any single type of incident. Table AIX re-estimates the relationship between Big Three ownership and governance-related incidents using pre-reform ownership, providing a robustness check analogous to Table AII for the scrutiny outcome. Table AX re-estimates the relationship between Big Three ownership and governance-related incidents by redefining the outcome variable as 1 only when governance-related risk incidents have low- and medium- reach information sources.

We also provide additional analyses to isolate the variation in female board representation that is driven by exposure to the “Womenomics” reform. Tables AXI and AXII report instrumental variable estimates that use the interaction between Big Three ownership and the post-reform period as an instrument for board gender diversity.

Finally, we examine whether the observed increase in governance-related incidents reflects underlying deterioration in firm performance or reporting quality. Tables AXIII and AXIV

examine firm performance, financial reporting quality, and external audit oversight. Across these analyses, we find no systematic evidence that exposure to investor-driven gender diversity reforms is associated with declines in firm fundamentals, consistent with the interpretation that externally reported governance-related incidents reflect increased judgment rather than underlying deterioration. Table AXV examines whether the observed increase in incidents reflects changes in their characteristics, showing that the increase is not driven by greater severity or reach but is associated with greater novelty in reporting.

Finally, we provide the “Nadeshiko Brand” evaluation process derived from the Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry website and regression models in robustness checks.

B. Variables and Measurement

TABLE AI Variable definitions

Variable	Definition	Source
Dependent variables		
Female ratio	Female director number divided by board size	LSEG Refinitive
Firm ratio ²⁰¹²	Female director number divided by board size in 2012	LSEG Refinitive
Female dummy	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has female directors on the board, and equals 0 in other cases.	LSEG Refinitive
Substitution	An indicator variable that equals 1 if in year $t + 1$, there was an increase in the number of female directors but no increase in board size compared with year t .	LSEG Refinitive
Addition	An indicator variable that equals 1 if in year $t + 1$, there was an increase in the number of female directors with an increase in board size compared with year t and otherwise 0.	LSEG Refinitive
Nadeshiko apply	An indicator variable that equals 1 if in year $t + 1$, the firm applies for (with agreement to be disclosed) the “Nadeshiko Brand”, and otherwise 0.	TSE website
Nadeshiko win	An indicator variable that equals 1 if in year $t + 1$, the firm is listed on the “Nadeshiko Brand”, and otherwise 0.	TSE website
Female director seats	Total seats a female director holds in other firms	LSEG Refinitive
Governance issues	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has governance risk incidents, including corruption, executive compensation, misleading communication, fraud, tax evasion, tax optimization, and anti-competition, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Severity indicator	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has the most severe (score = 3) governance risk incidents, otherwise 0.	Reprisk

Novelty indicator	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has the most novel (score = 2) governance risk incidents, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Reach indicator	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has the most widely reached (score = 3) governance risk incidents, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Severity mean	The year-mean of a firm's severity level of governance risk incidents.	Reprisk
Novelty mean	The year-mean of a firm's novelty level of governance risk incidents.	Reprisk
Reach mean	The year-mean of a firm's reach level of governance risk incidents.	Reprisk
Severe×reach mean	The year-mean of the multiplied severity and reach scores of a governance risk incident for a firm.	Reprisk
Corruption	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on corruption, bribery, extortion, and money laundering, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Executive compensation	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on executive compensation issues, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Misleading communication	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on misleading communication (including greenwashing), otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Fraud	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on fraud, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Tax evasion	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on tax evasion, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Tax optimization	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on tax optimization, otherwise 0.	Reprisk
Anti competition	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm has risk incidents on anti-competitive practices, otherwise 0.	Reprisk

CEO optimism	The first forecasting earning of the current year minus the previous year's realized earning, divided by last year's assets, scaled by one million.	TSE website
Revenue growth	The increase in a company's total sales compared to the previous year.	LSEG Refinitive
Employee growth	The increase in a company's number of employees compared to the previous year.	LSEG Refinitive
Restatements	An indicator variable if a firm has restatements.	TSE website
Revision number	Total number a firm discloses earnings forecast revisions in one fiscal year.	TSE website
Forecast gap	Absolute value of the first forecasting earning of the current year minus the realized earning, divided by previous year assets, scaled by one million.	TSE website
Earning surprise	An indicator variable that equals 1 if the realized earning is smaller than the last forecasting earning, otherwise 0.	TSE website
Audit fee	The natural logarithm of audit fees.	LSEG Refinitive

Independent variables

Big3 ownership	The percentage of the total outstanding shares held by Blackrock, Vanguard, and State Street.	LSEG Refinitive
Big3 ownership ²⁰¹²	The percentage of the total outstanding shares held by Blackrock, Vanguard, and State Street in 2012.	LSEG Refinitive
Non-Big3 foreign ownership	The percentage of the total outstanding shares held by non-Big3 foreign investors.	LSEG Refinitive
Non – Big3 foreign ownership ²⁰¹²	The percentage of the total outstanding shares held by non-Big3 foreign investors in 2012.	LSEG Refinitive

Big3 high	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm's Big Three holding is at or above year-industry mean level during 2012 – 2020, and equals 0 if a firm's Big Three holding is below year-industry mean level during 2012 – 2020.	LSEG Refinitive
Post 2013	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a year is equal or larger than 2013, and 0 otherwise.	LSEG Refinitive
ROE	The net income after tax over the total equity.	LSEG Refinitive
ROA	The net income after tax over the total assets.	LSEG Refinitive
Employee 301	And indicator variable that equals 1 if the number of employees exceeds 300, and 0 otherwise.	LSEG Refinitive
Sales ²⁰¹²	The natural logarithm of sales in 2012.	LSEG Refinitive
Market capitalization ²⁰¹²	The natural logarithm of market capitalization in 2012.	LSEG Refinitive
Assets ²⁰¹²	The natural logarithm of book value of assets in 2012.	LSEG Refinitive
MSCI ²⁰¹²	An indicator variable if a firm is in the MSCI Global index in 2012	MSCI index reconstitution files
S&P1200 ²⁰¹²	An indicator variable if a firm is in the S&P1200 Global index in 2012	WRDS
Board size ²⁰¹²	The number of directors on the board in 2012.	TSE website
Board independence ²⁰¹²	The proportion of outside board members over the total board size in 2012.	TSE website
Domestic concentration	The HHI index of domestic ownership.	LSEG Refinitive
Domestic bank ownership	The proportion of total outstanding shares held by domestic banks.	LSEG Refinitive

Domestic corporate ownership	The proportion of total outstanding shares held by domestic corporations.	LSEG Refinitive
Domestic employee ownership	The proportion of total outstanding shares held by domestic employees.	LSEG Refinitive
Cross ownership	The sum of stakes held by other listed companies (where the focal firm also has a stake).	LSEG Refinitive
No female industry ²⁰¹²	An indicator variable that equals 1 if an industry has no female directors in 2012, otherwise 0.	LSEG Refinitive
Employee number ²⁰¹²	The natural logarithm of employee numbers in 2012.	LSEG Refinitive
ROE shortfall ²⁰¹²	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm's ROE is above the industry average in 2012, otherwise 0.	LSEG Refinitive
ROA shortfall ²⁰¹²	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm's ROA is above the industry average in 2012, otherwise 0.	LSEG Refinitive
Tobin's Q shortfall ²⁰¹²	An indicator variable that equals 1 if a firm's Tobin's Q is above the industry average in 2012, otherwise 0.	LSEG Refinitive

C. Figure for contingent effects

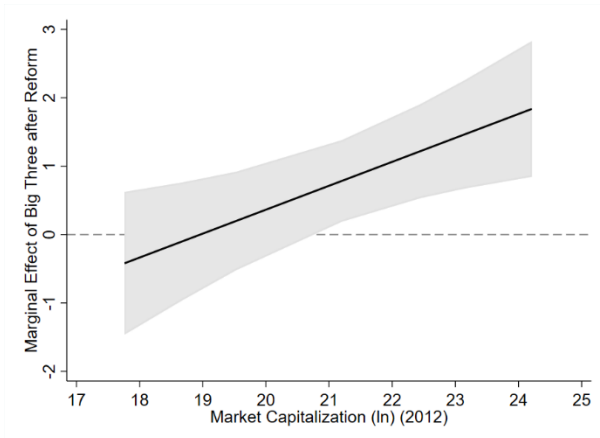
FIGURE A1 Conditional Marginal Effects of Big Three after Reform

This figure plots the marginal effects for each one-unit change in Big Three ownership on governance-related risk incidents after reform, contingent on no female director (industry) dummy (Panel A1.1), market capitalization (Panel A1.2), sales (Panel A1.3), assets (Panel A1.4), employee number (Panel A1.5), ROE shortfall (Panel A1.6), ROA shortfall (Panel A1.7), and Tobin's Q shortfall (Panel A1.8). Vertical bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Robust standard errors are clustered at the firm level. Estimation by OLS regression. Definitions of all variables are provided in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

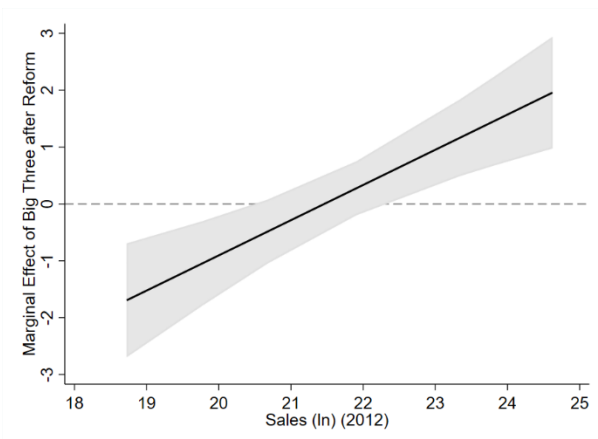
Panel A1.1 Contingent factor: No female director (ind.)



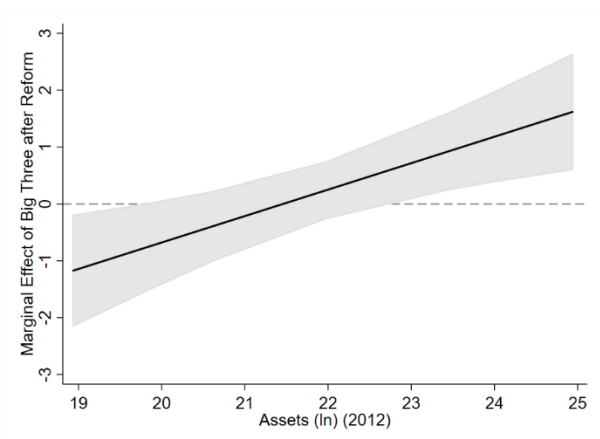
Panel A1.2 Contingent factor: Market capitalization



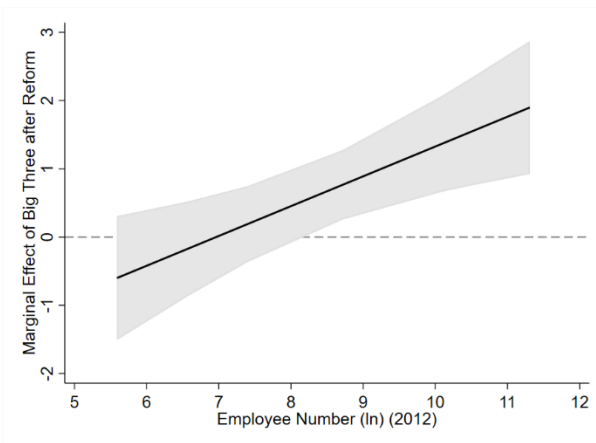
Panel A1.3 Contingent factor: Sales



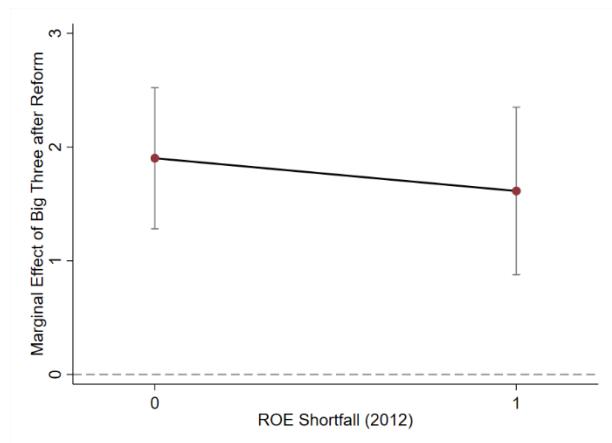
Panel A1.4 Contingent factor: Assets



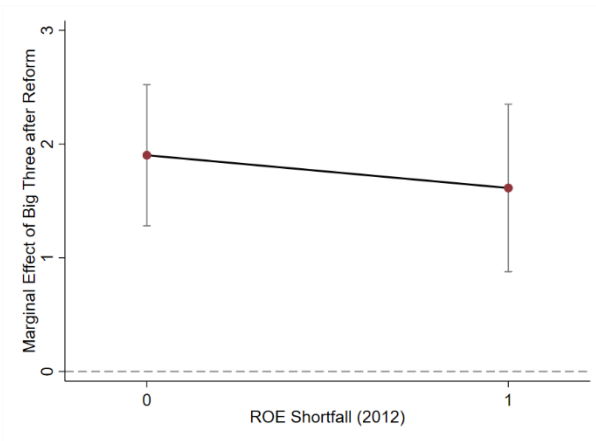
Panel A1.5 Contingent factor: Employee number



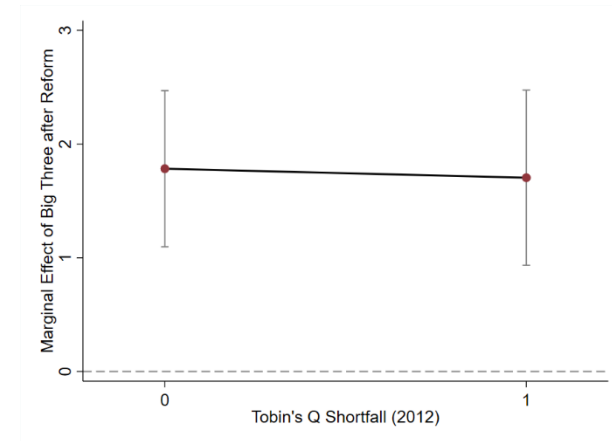
Panel A1.6 Contingent factor: ROE shortfall



Panel A1.7 Contingent factor: ROA shortfall



Panel A1.8 Contingent factor: Tobin's Q shortfall



D. Identification and Treatment Validity

TABLE AII Pre-Reform Trends in Big Three Ownership: Evidence from Female Ratio (2012)

Dependent variable	(1) Big3 Ownership
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2008	-0.015 (0.015)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2009	-0.020 (0.017)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2010	-0.010 (0.011)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2011	-0.001 (0.005)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2013	-0.004 (0.007)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2014	0.015 (0.012)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2015	0.038** (0.019)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2016	0.013 (0.018)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2017	0.020 (0.017)
Female ratio ²⁰¹² × Year = 2018	0.020 (0.017)
Constant	0.056*** (0.003)
Controls	Yes
Firm FE	Yes
Year FE	Yes
<i>N</i>	21076
Adjusted R ²	0.663

This table reports coefficients from regressions of Big Three Ownership on the interaction between a firm's female ratio on the board in 2012 and indicators for each year from 2008 through 2018. The dependent variable is the Big Three ownership. The sample includes firm-year observations from 2008 to 2018 and retains firms with non-continuous data as well as those that switch between high and low Big Three ownership groups. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AIII Pre-Reform Big Three Ownership (2012) and Board Gender Diversity

Dependent variable	(1) Female ratio	(2) Female dummy	(3) Substitution	(4) Addition	(5) Nadeshiko apply	(6) Nadeshiko win
Big3 ownership ²⁰¹² × Post 2013	0.660*** (0.137)	3.035*** (0.592)	0.617*** (0.185)	0.045 (0.106)	5.432*** (0.624)	1.246*** (0.292)
Constant	0.044*** (0.008)	0.262*** (0.039)	0.053*** (0.016)	0.011 (0.008)	0.104*** (0.030)	0.017 (0.013)
Z-statistic	2.540					
p-value	0.011					
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280
Adjusted R ²	0.544	0.538	0.038	0.014	0.411	0.245

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of female board representation on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership in 2012 and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are the female ratio on the board (Column (1)), whether there are females on the board (Column (2)), whether the females are appointed through substitution (Column (3)), whether females are appointed through extra addition (Column (4)), whether firms apply for the "Nadeshiko brand" (Column (5)), and whether firms are listed on the "Nadeshiko brand" (Column (6)). Z-statistic and p-value correspond to a z-test comparing the coefficients on the interaction terms in Columns (3) and (4). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AIV Binary Independent Variable Specification: Big Three Ownership and Board Gender Diversity

	(1) Female ratio	(2) Female dummy	(3) Substitution	(4) Addition	(5) Nadeshiko apply	(6) Nadeshiko win
Big3 high×Post 2013	0.054*** (0.008)	0.229*** (0.033)	0.042*** (0.011)	0.005 (0.006)	0.363*** (0.033)	0.091*** (0.017)
Constant	0.035*** (0.008)	0.229*** (0.038)	0.049*** (0.016)	0.010 (0.008)	0.067*** (0.026)	0.005 (0.014)
Z-statistic	2.866					
p-value	0.004					
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280	8280
Adjusted R ²	0.553	0.543	0.038	0.014	0.419	0.250

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of female board representation on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership level, measured using dummies and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are the female ratio on the board (Column (1)), whether there are females on the board (Column (2)), whether the females are appointed through substitution (Column (3)), whether females are appointed through extra addition (Column (4)), whether firms apply for the "Nadeshiko brand" (Column (5)), and whether firms are listed on the "Nadeshiko brand" (Column (6)). Z-statistic and p-value correspond to a z-test comparing the coefficients on the interaction terms in Columns (3) and (4). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AV Robustness to the 2015 Gender Disclosure Policy

Dependent variable	(1) Female ratio	(2) Female dummy	(3) Substitution	(4) Addition	(5) Nadeshiko apply	(6) Nadeshiko win
Big3 ownership	0.025 (0.077)	0.080 (0.296)	-0.006 (0.120)	0.005 (0.058)	-1.002*** (0.268)	-0.307 (0.201)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.485*** (0.085)	2.224*** (0.338)	0.367*** (0.122)	0.001 (0.061)	3.296*** (0.323)	0.876*** (0.197)
Employee 301×Year = 2006	0.010 (0.011)	0.111* (0.065)	0.010 (0.018)	0.005 (0.013)	0.007 (0.031)	0.018 (0.017)
Employee 301×Year = 2007	0.011 (0.011)	0.122* (0.071)	0.006 (0.019)	0.011 (0.013)	0.016 (0.039)	0.027 (0.022)
Employee 301×Year = 2008	0.008 (0.010)	0.117 (0.074)	0.002 (0.020)	0.001 (0.011)	0.008 (0.036)	0.019 (0.019)
Employee 301×Year = 2009	0.010 (0.010)	0.124* (0.073)	0.001 (0.020)	0.008 (0.012)	0.001 (0.035)	0.018 (0.018)
Employee 301×Year = 2010	0.011 (0.010)	0.133* (0.072)	0.003 (0.020)	0.002 (0.011)	0.004 (0.036)	0.020 (0.019)
Employee 301×Year = 2011	0.006 (0.009)	0.076 (0.060)	-0.003 (0.018)	-0.024 (0.032)	0.019 (0.033)	0.031* (0.017)
Employee 301×Year = 2012	0.016 (0.010)	0.129* (0.068)	0.012 (0.021)	0.009 (0.014)	0.015 (0.028)	0.038** (0.015)
Employee 301×Year = 2013	0.010 (0.010)	0.096 (0.067)	-0.001 (0.021)	0.009 (0.014)	0.072* (0.037)	0.030** (0.015)
Employee 301×Year = 2014	0.017 (0.010)	0.112 (0.071)	0.017 (0.022)	0.007 (0.037)	0.131*** (0.032)	0.032* (0.016)
Employee 301×Year = 2015	0.017* (0.010)	0.104 (0.074)	0.009 (0.043)	-0.002 (0.012)	0.107*** (0.035)	0.030* (0.017)
Employee 301×Year = 2016	0.017 (0.012)	0.151** (0.077)	-0.008 (0.046)	0.008 (0.014)	0.120*** (0.035)	0.026 (0.017)
Employee 301×Year = 2017	0.024** (0.012)	0.174** (0.077)	0.041* (0.023)	0.010 (0.013)	0.033 (0.035)	0.016 (0.015)
Employee 301×Year = 2018	0.036*** (0.011)	0.195*** (0.075)	0.055 (0.047)	-0.031 (0.042)	0.075** (0.032)	0.022 (0.015)
Employee 301×Year = 2019	0.032** (0.013)	0.168** (0.084)	-0.025 (0.061)	-0.018 (0.036)	0.034 (0.038)	0.022 (0.015)
Employee 301×Year = 2020	0.001 (0.015)	0.055 (0.108)	-0.092 (0.082)	0.027** (0.013)	0.041 (0.040)	0.020 (0.014)
Constant	0.007 (0.011)	0.044 (0.067)	0.042* (0.024)	0.009 (0.015)	0.026 (0.039)	-0.018 (0.020)
Z-statistic			2.408			
p-value			0.016			
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8064	8064	8064	8064	8064	8064
Adjusted R ²	0.557	0.549	0.039	0.014	0.401	0.246

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of female board representation on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013, and interactions between an indicator for having more than 300 employees and indicators for each year from 2006 through 2020. The dependent variables are the female ratio on the board (Column (1)), whether there are females on the board (Column (2)), whether the females are appointed through substitution (Column (3)), whether females are appointed through extra addition (Column (4)), whether firms apply for the "Nadeshiko brand" (Column (5)), and whether firms are listed on the "Nadeshiko brand" (Column (6)). Z-statistic and p-value correspond to a z-test comparing the coefficients on the interaction terms in Columns (3) and (4). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

E. Mechanism Extension: Director Supply and Board Appointments

TABLE AVI Female Director Cross-Board Appointments

Dependent variable	(1) Female director seats
Big3 ownership	-5.421 (3.996)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	5.835 (4.106)
Constant	1.392*** (0.062)
Director FE	Yes
Year FE	Yes
<i>N</i>	1269
Adjusted <i>R</i> ²	0.770

This table reports coefficients from director-panel regressions of female board seat numbers on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variable is the number of seats female directors hold in other firms. The sample includes director-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the director level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

F. External Scrutiny: Source, Composition, and Robustness

TABLE AVII Distribution of Governance-related Risk Incident by Reach (2007–2020)

Reach level	Description	Source	Percent (%)
1	Limited reach	Local media, local governmental bodies, smaller NGOs, and social media	23.80
2	Medium reach	Most national/regional media, state/regional governments, and international NGOs	62.01
3	High reach	Global outlets	14.19

This table shows the distribution of governance-related risk incidents by the reach of the information source. The data are incident-based and cover the period from 2007 to 2020. Full definitions of source and descriptions for each category are available on the RepRisk website (Methodology section).

TABLE AVIII Composition of Governance-Related Risk Incidents

Dependent variable	(1) Corruption	(2) Executive compensation	(3) Misleading communication	(4) Fraud	(5) Tax evasion	(6) Tax optimization	(7) Anti competition
Big3 ownership	0.036 (0.214)	-0.026 (0.020)	-0.060 (0.081)	-0.181 (0.217)	-0.016 (0.041)	0.002 (0.032)	-0.043 (0.244)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.471*** (0.178)	0.015 (0.024)	0.605*** (0.130)	1.163*** (0.224)	0.157** (0.066)	0.100*** (0.037)	0.993*** (0.263)
Constant	0.024* (0.013)	0.006** (0.003)	0.016 (0.010)	0.022 (0.015)	-0.003 (0.005)	-0.006* (0.003)	0.029 (0.019)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265
Adjusted <i>R</i> ²	0.316	0.038	0.236	0.365	0.086	0.028	0.309

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of specific governance risk incidents on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are whether there are risk incidents on corruption (Column (1)), executive compensation (Column (2)), misleading communication (Column (3)), fraud (Column (4)), tax evasion (Column (5)), tax optimization (Column (6)), and anti competition (Column (7)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AIX Pre-Reform Big Three Ownership (2012) and Governance-Related Risk Incidents

Dependent variable	(1) Governance issues	(2) Corruption	(3) Executive compensation	(4) Misleading communication	(5) Fraud	(6) Tax evasion	(7) Tax optimization	(8) Anti competition
Big3 ownership ²⁰¹² × Post 2013	2.978*** (0.436)	0.767*** (0.211)	0.023 (0.047)	0.863*** (0.186)	2.156*** (0.361)	0.309*** (0.116)	0.177*** (0.056)	1.572*** (0.378)
Constant	0.120*** (0.024)	0.042*** (0.012)	0.005 (0.003)	0.034*** (0.011)	0.038** (0.015)	-0.001 (0.006)	-0.003 (0.003)	0.058*** (0.020)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265
Adjusted R ²	0.409	0.313	0.038	0.230	0.367	0.086	0.028	0.304

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of governance risk incidents on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership in 2012 and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are whether there are governance risk incidents (Column (1)), risk incidents on corruption (Column (2)), executive compensation (Column (3)), misleading communication (Column (4)), fraud (Column (5)), tax evasion (Column (6)), tax optimization (Column (7)), and anti competition (Column (8)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AX Limited- and Medium-Reach Governance Risk Incidents

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
Dependent variable	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues	Governanc e issues
Big3 ownership	-0.174 (0.260)	-0.167 (0.260)	-0.072 (0.253)	-0.006 (0.248)	0.006 (0.249)	-0.167 (0.259)	0.002 (0.262)	-0.173 (0.260)	-0.135 (0.258)	-0.040 (0.252)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	1.753*** (0.244)	1.728*** (0.247)	1.131*** (0.288)	0.943*** (0.260)	0.844*** (0.276)	1.702*** (0.247)	1.179*** (0.301)	1.736*** (0.254)	1.627*** (0.246)	1.049*** (0.288)
Female zero ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013		-0.027 (0.027)								-0.007 (0.028)
Market capitalization ²⁰¹² ×Post2 013 2013			0.024*** (0.006)							0.024*** (0.006)
Sales ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013				0.035*** (0.006)						
Assets ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013					0.037*** (0.006)					
MSCI ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013						0.059 (0.053)				0.037 (0.052)
S&P1200 ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013							0.113*** (0.034)			
Board size ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013								0.001 (0.002)		-0.003 (0.002)
Board independence ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013									0.120*** (0.042)	0.088** (0.042)
Constant	0.068*** (0.021)	0.082*** (0.024)	-0.175*** (0.062)	-0.321*** (0.066)	-0.343*** (0.072)	0.068*** (0.021)	0.060*** (0.020)	0.065*** (0.022)	0.065*** (0.021)	-0.165** (0.068)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265
Adjusted R ²	0.409	0.409	0.411	0.414	0.414	0.409	0.412	0.409	0.410	0.412

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of governance risk incidents on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variable equals 1 if there are governance-related risk incidents with limited- and medium- reach information source, and 0 otherwise. Columns (2) include a control for no female director indicator in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (3) includes a control for log market cap in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (4) includes a control for log assets in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (5) includes a control for log sales in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (6) includes a control for MSCI Index inclusion in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (7) includes a control for S&P 1200 Index inclusion in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (8) includes a control for board size in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (9) includes a control for board independence in 2012 interacted with Post2013. Column (10) includes controls for the no-female-director indicator, log market capitalization, MSCI Index inclusion, board size, and board independence, with their 2012 values interacted with the Post-2013 indicator. The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

G. Causal Interpretation of Gender Diversity and Scrutiny

TABLE AXI Instrumental Variable Estimates: Female Director Ratio

Dependent variable	(1) Governance issues	(2) Corruption	(3) Executive compensation	(4) Misleading communication	(5) Fraud	(6) Tax evasion	(7) Tax optimization	(8) Anti competition
Female ratio	3.765*** (0.848)	0.985** (0.411)	0.032 (0.051)	1.265*** (0.282)	2.431*** (0.624)	0.329** (0.148)	0.209*** (0.080)	2.076*** (0.631)
Big3 ownership	-0.320 (0.454)	0.007 (0.261)	-0.027 (0.020)	-0.097 (0.108)	-0.253 (0.312)	-0.026 (0.050)	-0.004 (0.036)	-0.105 (0.287)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265
Kleibergen-Paap rk	38.07	38.07	38.07	38.07	38.07	38.07	38.07	38.07
Wald F statistic								

This table reports coefficients from second-stage firm-panel regressions of governance risk incidents on the female ratio on the board using the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013 as an IV, firm and year fixed effects (FE). The dependent variables are whether there are governance risk incidents (Column (1)), risk incidents on corruption (Column (2)), executive compensation (Column (3)), misleading communication (Column (4)), fraud (Column (5)), tax evasion (Column (6)), tax optimization (Column (7)), and anti competition (Column (8)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AXII Instrumental Variable Estimates: Female Director Indicator

Dependent variable	(1) Governance issues	(2) Corruption	(3) Executive compensation	(4) Misleading communication	(5) Fraud	(6) Tax evasion	(7) Tax optimization	(8) Anti competition
Female dummy	0.861*** (0.188)	0.225** (0.092)	0.007 (0.012)	0.289*** (0.067)	0.556*** (0.139)	0.075** (0.033)	0.048*** (0.018)	0.475*** (0.151)
Big3 ownership	-0.301 (0.423)	0.012 (0.245)	-0.027 (0.020)	-0.091 (0.105)	-0.241 (0.305)	-0.024 (0.047)	-0.003 (0.036)	-0.094 (0.299)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265	8265
Kleibergen-Paap rk	42.97	42.97	42.97	42.97	42.97	42.97	42.97	42.97
Wald F statistic								

This table reports coefficients from second-stage firm-panel regressions of governance risk incidents on the female indicator on the board using the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013 as an IV, firm and year fixed effects (FE). The dependent variables are whether there is governance risk incidents (Column (1)), risk incidents on corruption (Column (2)), executive compensation (Column (3)), misleading communication (Column (4)), fraud (Column (5)), tax evasion (Column (6)), tax optimization (Column (7)), and anti competition (Column (8)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

H. Alternative Explanation: Firm Performance and Governance Quality

TABLE AXIII Big Three Ownership and Firm Performance

Dependent variable	(1) ROE	(2) ROA	(3) CEO optimism	(4) Revenue growth	(5) Employee growth
Big3 ownership	-0.018 (0.051)	0.008 (0.020)	0.890 (2.177)	-0.001 (0.066)	-0.016 (0.058)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.187*** (0.070)	0.053** (0.023)	-2.783 (2.085)	0.035 (0.076)	0.007 (0.067)
Market capitalization ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013	-0.007*** (0.002)	-0.003*** (0.001)	0.194*** (0.055)	-0.006*** (0.002)	-0.004** (0.002)
Board independence ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013	0.007 (0.017)	0.004 (0.006)	0.558 (0.479)	0.023 (0.017)	0.025 (0.018)
Constant	0.117*** (0.019)	0.046*** (0.007)	-2.780*** (0.765)	0.089*** (0.023)	0.071*** (0.020)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8280	8280	6949	8280	7880
Adjusted <i>R</i> ²	0.180	0.278	0.127	0.442	0.105

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of firm performance and firm size growth on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are ROE (Column (1)), ROA (Column (2)), forecast innovation (Column (3)), revenue growth (Column (4)), and employee growth (Column (5)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AXIV Big Three Ownership and Governance (Financial Reporting and External Audit Oversight)

Dependent variable	(1) Restatements	(2) Revision number	(3) Forecast gap	(4) Earnings	(5) Audit fee
Big3 ownership	0.015 (0.054)	0.191 (0.656)	3.428*** (1.310)	-0.002 (0.435)	0.577 (0.395)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.072 (0.077)	0.777 (0.823)	-2.298 (1.497)	-0.225 (0.442)	0.018 (0.447)
Market capitalization ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013	0.003 (0.002)	0.039** (0.020)	0.084** (0.041)	0.012 (0.010)	0.081*** (0.011)
Board independence ²⁰¹² ×Post 2013	0.001 (0.018)	0.016 (0.197)	0.264 (0.481)	-0.145* (0.078)	0.133 (0.114)
Constant	-0.033 (0.024)	0.722*** (0.229)	0.117 (0.530)	0.157 (0.120)	12.519*** (0.124)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	8280	8073	7476	7519	7608
Adjusted R ²	0.019	0.308	0.254	0.066	0.927

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of governance (financial reporting and oversight) on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are restatements (Column (1)), revision number (Column (2)), forecast gap (Column (3)), earnings surprise (Column (4)), and audit fees (Column (5)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2006 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

TABLE AXV Incident Characteristics (Severity, Reach, and Novelty)

Dependent variable	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
	Severity		Reach		Novelty		Severe×reach mean
	Dummy	Mean	Dummy	Mean	Dummy	Mean	
Big3 ownership	0.146 (0.178)	-0.508 (1.087)	0.328 (1.189)	0.044 (0.891)	-2.641** (1.295)	-2.773*** (0.937)	-0.677 (1.808)
Big3 ownership×Post 2013	0.239 (0.215)	0.439 (1.181)	0.314 (1.157)	0.614 (0.858)	3.266*** (1.141)	2.883*** (0.831)	1.851 (1.879)
Constant	-0.064 (0.074)	1.319*** (0.240)	0.305 (0.225)	1.863*** (0.184)	0.535*** (0.162)	1.362*** (0.156)	2.475*** (0.427)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Constant	590	590	590	590	585	585	585
Adjusted R ²	-0.040	0.196	0.214	0.119	0.058	0.223	0.062

This table reports coefficients from firm-panel regressions of severity, reach, and novelty of governance risk incidents on the interaction between a firm's Big Three ownership and an indicator for years in and after 2013. The dependent variables are severity (Columns (1) and (2)), reach (Columns (3) and (4)), novelty (Columns (5) and (6)), and severity multiplied by reach (Column (7)). The sample includes firm-year observations from 2007 through 2020. Standard errors, which are adjusted for clustering at the firm level, are reported in parentheses. All variables are defined in Online Appendix S1 Table AI.

I. Institutional Background: The “Nadeshiko Brand” Evaluation Process

The Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry (METI) selects outstanding companies through the Survey on Companies Encouraging Women’s Empowerment in the Workplace, which assesses firms’ efforts to promote women’s empowerment. Based on survey responses, METI evaluates companies and identifies those demonstrating innovative and effective practices

The survey focuses on three key areas:

- (1) initiatives to address gender pay gaps and related challenges.
- (2) efforts to implement diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) practices across their supply chains and partner networks.
- (3) measurable outcomes from programs addressing health-related issues for female employees.

An evaluation committee reviews the survey results and selects the top-performing firms, typically one to two companies per industry. On average, this corresponds to a 12% selection rate of all responding firms, which are designated as “Nadeshiko Brands.”

Source: Companies Selected under the FY2024 “Nadeshiko Brands” and “Next Nadeshiko: Companies Supporting Dual Careers and Co-parenting” (March, 2025)
https://www.meti.go.jp/english/press/2025/0324_001.html

J. Regression Models in Robustness Checks

1. Models to estimate using Big Three ownership in 2012:

$$GenderDiv_{it+1} = \beta_1 Big3\ ownership_i^{2012} \times Post2013_t + \beta_2 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

$$Govern\ issues_{it+1} = \beta_1 Big3\ ownership_i^{2012} \times Post2013_t + \beta_2 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it}$$

(2)

$Big3\ ownership_i^{2012}$ is the share of firm i's equity held by The Big Three in year 2012.

Our results are robust, using Big Three shareholdings in 2012 as treatment.

2. Models to estimate using Big Three ownership dummy:

$$GenderDiv_{it+1} = \beta_1 Big3\ high_i \times Post2013_t + \beta_2 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (3)$$

$Big3\ high_i$ is an indicator variable that equals 1 if firm i's Big Three holding is at or above the year-industry mean level during 2012 - 2020, and equals 0 if firm i's Big Three holding is below the year-industry mean level during 2012 - 2020.

3. Models for the Instrumental variable approach:

First stage:

$$GenderDiv_{it} = \beta_1 Big3\ ownership_{it} \times Post2013_t + \beta_2 Big3\ ownership_{it} + \beta_3 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (4)$$

Second stage:

$$Govern\ issues_{it+1} = \theta_1 \widehat{GenderDiv}_{it} + \theta_2 Big3\ ownership_{it} + \theta_3 X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (5)$$